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Esther

Esther 1:1

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:1a

This is what happened in the days of Xerxes,

- ¶ The following story/events took place while Xerxes was king.

This is what happened: In Hebrew, the story begins with a word which many versions do not translate at all (see 1:1 in GNT, CEV). If you have a special way in your language to indicate the beginning of a story, you should use it here.

Xerxes: Xerxes was the king of the Persian Empire from 485–464 BC. Xerxes was his name in Greek. In the Hebrew text, his name is given as Ahasuerus and a number of English versions use this form (KJV, NJPS, RSV). You should follow the English version most commonly used in your area.

1:1b

who reigned over 127 provinces

- This was the Xerxes who was king over 127 regions/districts/areas.

provinces: The Persian Empire was so large that it was divided into 127 districts, called provinces in the BSB. The king appointed officials in each province so that the whole empire could be governed well.

1:1c

from India to Cush.

- He ruled over the countries/lands from the country of India in the east to the country of Ethiopia in the west.
- He ruled over India and Ethiopia and everywhere in between.

India: This was the same area as present day India and was the part of the Persian Empire furthest to the east.

Cush: This referred to the upper Nile region which today is known as Ethiopia. It was the part of the Persian Empire furthest to the west.

Esther 1:2

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:2

In those days King Xerxes sat on his royal throne in the citadel of Susa.

- At the time this story took place he was governing the empire from his palace in the city of Susa.

his royal throne: A throne is the special seat on which a king would sit, especially on special occasions when he was meeting with officials or other visitors. It may have been decorated with or even made of gold. Here, however, it is used in a figurative way and refers only to the fact that he was king. The Display shows one way of translating this meaning.

citadel of Susa: There were three major cities in the empire, and the king had a palace in each one. This story took place in the city of Susa, where the king lived during the winter. The Hebrew word which the BSB translates citadel means “palace, fortress” and refers to a part of the city which was raised above the rest of the city and fortified with high walls against attack. The king’s palace would probably have been inside this fortified area.

Here are some other ways to translate citadel:

capital city (GNT, CEV)

important city

capital city

Esther 1:3

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

Paragraph 1:3–4

The king displayed his riches to the officials of his kingdom for six months. During this time he may have been planning the battles against Greece which took place from 482–479 BC. At the end of the six months, he gave a huge feast for his officials and the public which lasted for a week.

1:3a

In the third year of his reign, Xerxes held a feast for all his officials and servants.

- ¶ During the third year that he was king, he gave a big feast for all the officials/administrators and other important men in his kingdom.

officials: This is the first of five groups of important people mentioned in this verse as guests at the banquet. The word in Hebrew which the BSB translates officials is a general term for a leader or other important person and refers to someone whom the king has appointed to that position.

servants: Literally “servants/slaves.” Here it does not refer to ordinary servants but those of high rank. The BSB has servants; GNT has “administrators.”

If you translate “officials” as “important people,” you may want to switch the two terms and say, for example, “administrators and other important people.”

1:3b

The military leaders of Persia and Media were there, along with the nobles and princes of the provinces.

- The people the king invited to the feast were the army chiefs of Persia and Media, and the governors and other important men in his provinces.

Three more groups of leaders are mentioned in this part of the verse. However, this was probably just another way of referring to the same people as in 1:3a. This is how the Display has linked the two parts of the verse.

military leaders: This is literally “armies.” However, it is more likely that the term refers here only to the army chiefs, not to all the soldiers (as BSB, NIV, RSV, NCV, CEV), and it is recommended that you translate it in this way.

Persia and Media: The Persian Empire was made up of these two kingdoms, which were ruled by the same king.

nobles: The Hebrew word here refers to important officials, governors ruling over a district or province.

princes: This is the same word that was translated “officials” in 1:3a.

Esther 1:4**Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast**

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and

the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

Paragraph 1:3–4

The king displayed his riches to the officials of his kingdom for six months. During this time he may have been planning the battles against Greece which took place from 482–479 BC. At the end of the six months, he gave a huge feast for his officials and the public which lasted for a week.

1:4

And for a full 180 days he displayed the glorious riches of his kingdom and the magnificent splendor of his greatness.

- The celebrations lasted six months. During all that time he showed them his great riches and all the beautiful and splendid things which showed how great a king he was.

the magnificent splendor: This refers to the magnificent possessions of the king.

his greatness: This refers to his position as king.

Esther 1:5**Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast**

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:5a

At the end of this time,

- ¶ At the end of the six months,

At the end of this time: That is, at the end of the six months.

1:5b

in the garden court of the royal palace, the king held a seven-day feast

- the king held another big feast in the enclosed gardens surrounding his palace. This feast lasted seven days.

garden court: This means an area outside where there were grass, trees and flowers, and possibly paved areas. It does not mean a place where food is grown. It was probably surrounded by hedges or walls. The BSB states this explicitly by saying garden court.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

enclosed garden (NIV)

courtyard (NCV)

the royal palace: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates palace probably refers to a small building apart from the main palace buildings. It was a roof set on columns to shelter people from the sun, but allowing the breezes to pass through.

the king held a seven-day feast: It isn't clear whether this refers to another banquet or the same banquet as the one mentioned in 1:3. In those days, banquets could last as long as six months. However, it is more logical in the context to understand it to mean a separate banquet which was held at the end of the six months. CEV and NCV have stated that meaning explicitly by adding "another."

1:5c

for all the people in the citadel of Susa, from the least to the greatest.

- He invited everyone from the city of Susa to the feast, rich and poor alike.

in the citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

from the least to the greatest: This was a way of including everyone. least probably refers to the poorest and greatest to the richest in this context.

Esther 1:6

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:6

This verse describes how the garden was decorated. There were marble pillars around the edge of the garden. Blue and white curtains were hung between these pillars and were tied to silver rings on the pillars by purple and white cords. Blue and white were the royal colors of Persia. The meaning of many of the Hebrew words in this verse is not known and that is why there are many differences in detail between the English versions.

1:6a

Hangings of white and blue linen were fastened

- There were curtains made of white and blue fine material in the garden.

Hangings of white and blue linen: This probably refers to two separate sets of curtains, one set blue and the other white, not two-colored curtains.

linen: This is a finely woven cloth made from the flax plant.

1:6b

with cords of fine white and purple material to silver rings on the marble pillars.

- These were attached by cords to silver rings on pillars made of beautiful stone. These cords were made from white linen cloth and purple material.

purple: Purple is a color between red and blue.

silver rings: This could refer to:

1. rings made of silver which were attached to or embedded in the pillars (BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV, CEV).
2. silver rods which joined the pillars (NJPS, GW).

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

marble: This is a kind of beautiful stone. It is hard and usually shiny. It can be different colors—white, black or white with stripes of other colors in it. It was used for pillars or for paving, as well as for statues.

1:6c

Gold and silver couches were arranged

- There were long seats made of gold and silver so that people could lie on them while they ate

couches: This means a long low seat, often soft, where someone would normally recline (lie) to eat.

1:6d

on a mosaic pavement of porphyry, marble, mother-of-pearl, and other costly stones.

- These seats were on a floor that people had paved with beautiful stones of different colors.

mosaic pavement: The ground where the couches were was covered with beautiful stones of different colors arranged in patterns. There are four types of stone listed, but scholars are not sure what the Hebrew words mean, so nearly every version has a different translation. The important thing is that the area was paved with beautiful stones of different colors and this is how the verse has been translated in the Display. It is recommended that you do the same, rather than introducing names of stones which your readers do not know.

Esther 1:7

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:7a

Beverages were served in an array of goblets of gold, each with a different design,

- During the feast beverages were served in cups made of gold. Each cup was made in a different design.

Beverages were served: The rest of the verse says that the beverages were wine. However, the text does not say who was serving the beverages. If your language has no passive, you may need to say something like: “The king’s servants served the beverages....”

goblets of gold: This word refers to specially designed and decorated cups.

1:7b

and the royal wine flowed freely, according to the king’s bounty.

- There was plenty of wine for the guests to drink because the king was generous.
- The king provided plenty of wine for his guests to drink because he was generous.

Esther 1:8

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:8a

By order of the king, no limit was placed on the drinking,

- Everyone was allowed to drink as much as he wanted,

no limit was placed on the drinking: This means that each man was free to drink as much or as little as he chose. There was so much wine available that a person could drink a lot if he wanted, but he was not compelled to do so.

1:8b

and every official of his household was to serve each man whatever he desired.

- because the king had ordered his servants to keep on pouring out wine as long as the people still wanted to drink.

every official of his household: This refers to the servants whose job was to pour the wine for the guests.

whatever he desired: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as whatever he desired means “as much as he wanted.”

Esther 1:9

Section 1:1–9: King Xerxes gave a big feast

This section describes the setting for the story. It begins with a description of the Persian Empire and the feast which King Xerxes held in the third year of his reign to show his people how rich he was.

1:9

Queen Vashti also gave a banquet for the women in the royal palace of King Xerxes.

- At the same time the wife of the king, whose name was Vashti, also gave a banquet in another part of the palace for the women.

banquet: This means a big feast where there was a lot to eat and drink. In Xerxes’ time, these banquets lasted many days or even weeks.

for the women: The text does not explain who these women were, but they may have been the wives of the officials who were feasting with the king.

Esther 1:10

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen’s disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:10a

On the seventh day, when the king’s heart was merry with wine,

- ¶ On the seventh day of the feast, King Xerxes felt very happy because of all the wine he had drunk.

the king’s heart was merry with wine: Literally, “the heart of the king was good with wine.” By the last day of the feast, the king had drunk a lot of wine. If you have alcoholic drinks in your area, you probably have an expression to describe a person who has drunk enough wine to make him think he is very happy. You should use that expression here.

1:10b

he ordered the seven eunuchs who served him—Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar, and Carkas—

- So he gave an order to the seven chief servants who looked after him. Their names were Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar and Carkas.

eunuchs: Many of the king's servants were eunuchs, that is, men who had been castrated and therefore could no longer have sexual relations with a women. In ancient times a king would use such men to protect his wives because they would not try to have sexual relations with the women. If a literal translation would shock your readers or be too difficult to translate, then use a word for an important servant, and explain the meaning of "eunuch" in a footnote or in the glossary.

who served him: Literally "who served the face of the king." This probably refers to the king's personal servants, who were responsible for looking after him.

Esther 1:11

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:11a

to bring Queen Vashti before him, wearing her royal crown,

- He told them to go to Queen Vashti and tell her to put on her crown, and then to bring her to him at the feast.

her royal crown: A crown is the special kind of hat a king or queen wears. In Europe, a crown is usually made of gold, but in Persia, it was probably a special sort of turban, that is, a long cloth wound round and round and fastened with some sort of jewel.

1:11b

to display her beauty to the people and officials. For she was beautiful to behold.

- He wanted to show his officials and the other people at the feast, how very beautiful she was.
- He wanted the officials and the other people to see that she was very beautiful.

officials: See note on 1:3a.

Esther 1:12

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:12a

Queen Vashti, however, refused to come at the king's command brought by his eunuchs.

- But when the servants gave the king's message/order to Queen Vashti, she refused to obey.

1:12b

And the king became furious, and his anger burned within him.

- When he heard this, the king became very angry.

became furious, and his anger burned within him:

The Hebrew uses two expressions to show how very angry the king was. You need to decide whether you should use two expressions in your language or just one very strong expression to show the same thing.

Esther 1:13

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their

husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:13a

Then the king consulted the wise men who knew the times,

- He summoned his advisors who knew what should be done about such matters as the queen's disobedience and consulted them,

the wise men who knew the times: There is a textual problem with this verse, in particular with the word translated times by the BSB. The two possibilities are:

1. The text has the Hebrew word *ʾitîm* "times." This is the text followed by the majority of the translations. This means the phrase could refer to astrologers, but here it probably refers to men who were experts in legal matters. For example, the GNT has:

his advisers, who would know what should be done

1. The text has *daʿîm*, the plural of the word the BSB translates "law" in 1:13b. For example, the NRSV and NJB have:

who knew the laws

It is recommended that you follow the first option like the GNT.

1:13b

for it was customary for him to confer with the experts in law and justice.

- because it was normal for the king to ask advice from wise men who knew all about the law and how to judge things.

law and justice: The Hebrew words *daʿ* and *dîn*, translated law and justice in the BSB, go together. The second one probably refers to legal procedures.

Esther 1:14

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said

that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:14a

His closest advisors were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena, and Memucan,

- The names of the men he trusted the most were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena and Memucan.

1:14b

the seven princes of Persia and Media who had personal access to the king and ranked highest in the kingdom.

- These seven men were the most important officials in the kingdom of Persia and Media and they were permitted to talk openly/freely to the king.

princes: See note on 1:3b.

who had personal access to the king: Literally "who saw the king's face." This means that they were allowed to enter the king's presence freely and talk with him because he trusted them.

Esther 1:15

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:15a

"According to law," he asked, "what should be done with Queen Vashti,

- The king said to these men, "What does the law say should happen to Queen Vashti?"

he asked: The BSB has added this to make it clear that the king has begun to speak. You will probably need to do something similar.

1:15b

since she refused to obey the command of King Xerxes delivered by the eunuchs?"

- Because I, the king, sent an order to her by my servants and she refused to obey it.”

the command of King Xerxes: Consider whether in your language the king should refer to himself as King Xerxes, or whether this should be translated as “my command.”

Esther 1:16

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen’s disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:16a

And in the presence of the king and his princes, Memucan replied,

- ¶ Then Memucan said to the king in front of the other important men,

princes: See note on 1:3b.

1:16b

“Queen Vashti has wronged not only the king, but all the princes and the peoples in all the provinces of King Xerxes.

- “Vashti, the queen, has done wrong. She has insulted not only you, the king, but she has also insulted all your officials and the people in every part of your kingdom.

wronged not only the king: Memucan did not refer to the king as “you” although he was speaking directly to him. You need to decide whether you can do this or whether you need to say “you.” If you have a special way of addressing a chief, you need to consider if you should use it here. For example, the CEV has:

Your Majesty, Queen Vashti has not only embarrassed you

princes: See note on 1:3b.

Esther 1:17

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen’s disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:17a

For the conduct of the queen will become known to all women,

- For all the other women in the kingdom will hear what the queen has done,
- For all the other women in the kingdom will hear about the way the queen has behaved,

1:17b

causing them to despise their husbands

- and so they will begin also to show disrespect to their husbands.
- and as a result they will no longer respect their husbands.

1:17c

and say, ‘King Xerxes ordered Queen Vashti to be brought before him, but she did not come.’

- Instead, they will say that when the king ordered his servants to bring Queen Vashti to him, she refused to come, so why should they obey their husbands.
- For they will say, ‘Queen Vashti refused to come to King Xerxes when he sent for her, so we do not need to do what our husbands tell us’

1:17

You may need to add something to what the women are reported as saying in order to make it clear why this worried the nobles. The Display shows one way to do this.

Esther 1:18

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to

be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:18a

This very day the noble women of Persia and Media who have heard about the queen's conduct will say the same thing to all the king's officials,

- Already some of the wives of the important men of Persia and Media have heard about what the queen has done, and they also will begin to disobey their husbands.
- Already some of the wives of the important men of Persia and Media have heard how the queen has behaved, and they will begin to behave in the same way towards their own husbands.

the king's officials: See note on 1:3a.

1:18b

resulting in much contempt and wrath.

- As a result, all through the kingdom, women will no longer respect their husbands, and their husbands will be angry with them because of this.

much contempt and wrath: There would be discord or quarrels between husbands and their wives, because the husbands would be angry about their wives' behavior.

Esther 1:19

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:19a

So if it pleases the king, let him issue a royal decree,

- So, your Majesty, if you think it a good idea, give an order

1:19b

and let it be recorded in the laws of Persia and Media so that it cannot be repealed,

- which your officials should add to the other laws of the kingdom of Persia and Media, laws which no one can ever revoke.
- and cause it to be written down with all the other laws of Persia and Media, laws which no one can cancel.

1:19a-b

So if it pleases the king: This phrase is used often in Esther when someone suggests something to the king. It is a polite way to say "if you agree."

a royal decree: This means a command or order issued by the king.

1:19c

that Vashti shall never again enter the presence of King Xerxes,

- The order should say that Vashti should never be allowed to come into your presence again.

Vashti shall never again enter the presence of King Xerxes:

This implied that the king should never again permit Vashti to approach him either as queen or as wife.

1:19d

and that her royal position shall be given to a woman better than she.

- Then you should choose another woman, someone better than she, and make her the queen instead.

her royal position: That is, her position as queen.

Esther 1:20

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen's disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:20a

The edict the king issues will be heard throughout his vast kingdom—

- Then when news of your order spreads to all the towns of your large kingdom,
- Then when everyone in your huge kingdom hears what you have ordered to happen to Queen Vashti,

The edict the king issues: This has a similar meaning to “decree” in 1:19a.

1:20b

and so all women, from the least to the greatest, will honor their husbands.”

- every woman in the kingdom, whether rich or poor, will respect her husband.”

from the least to the greatest: See note on 1:5c.

Esther 1:21

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen’s disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:21a

The king and his princes were pleased with this counsel;

- ¶ This advice pleased the king and his officials,

1:21b

so the king did as Memucan had advised.

- and so the king did what Memucan suggested.

1:21

princes: See note on 1:3b.

Esther 1:22

Section 1:10–22: Queen Vashti disobeyed the king and he removed her from her position as queen

Towards the end of the feast, when he had drunk too much wine, the king sent a message, ordering the queen to come to him so that he could show off her beauty to his guests. But she probably did not wish to be seen by a crowd of drunken, leering men, and so she refused. The king was very angry about the queen’s disobedience and asked his advisors what the law said about how she should be punished. The advisors said

that the king should divorce the queen, in order to show all wives in the empire that they must obey their husbands. The king was pleased with this advice and issued a decree to inform everyone about it.

1:22a

He sent letters to all the provinces of the kingdom,

- He sent messengers with written messages to every part of his kingdom.

letters: This means written messages, which would have been taken by messengers throughout the kingdom.

1:22b

to each province in its own script and to each people in their own language,

- Each message was written in the language and way of writing of the people who would receive it.

script: This means the alphabet people used to write their language. For example, if you write Hebrew, you use a different script from English.

1:22c

proclaiming that every man should be master of his own household.

- In each message, written in the language of the people to whom it was written, the king gave the order that each man should be in control of his own family.

in their own language: This phrase is at the end of the verse in Hebrew and is literally “and speaking according to the language of his people.” Commentators and translators have found it difficult to understand this phrase and have many different solutions. Some of the possibilities are:

1. It is referring again to the language in which the message was to be written and announced (BSB, NIV, NLT).
2. The LXX (Greek OT) omitted the phrase completely and some English versions do the same (NJB, NRSV, CEV, NCV).
3. The husband should speak with final authority (GNT).

You may want to follow the interpretation of the major national translation in your area. The Display follows the first interpretation.

Esther 2:1

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them.

When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:1a

Some time later, when the anger of King Xerxes had subsided, he remembered Vashti

- ¶ Later, after the king had stopped being angry about what Vashti had done, he thought about Vashti again.

2:1b

and what she had done, and what had been decreed against her.

- He thought about what she had done and also about the order that he had made about her.

2:1

Some time later: This is a vague term. It may have been three or four years after the events of chapter 1, and after the king had returned from a war with Greece, since 2:16 states that Esther went to the king in the seventh year of Xerxes' reign.

Esther 2:2

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:2a

Then the king's attendants proposed,

- Then some of the king's personal servants suggested to him,

the king's attendants: This is the same expression as the BSB translated "who served him" in 1:10b. See note there.

2:2b

"Let a search be made for beautiful young virgins for the king,

- "Your Majesty, send some of your officials to go and find beautiful young virgins, and let them bring them to you.

Once more the servants were speaking directly to the king. You need to consider how it would be appropriate for them to address him.

virgins: This is a woman who has not had sexual relations with a man.

Esther 2:3

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:3a

and let the king appoint commissioners in each province of his kingdom

- Choose officials in every district of your kingdom

commissioners: This was another kind of official.

2:3b

to assemble all the beautiful young women into the harem at the citadel of Susa.

- to go and find all these beautiful girls. Then they should bring them to the house of your concubines in your palace here in Susa.

harem: This was the area of the palace where the concubines of the king lived. A concubine is a woman who is a secondary wife, that is, who is not legally married to a man but who lives like his wife. Usually a man would have several concubines but fewer legal wives.

citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

2:3c

Let them be placed under the care of Hegai, the king's eunuch in charge of the women,

- Then Hegai, your important servant, who looks after your concubines, should look after the girls.
- There they should give them to Hegai, the servant who looks after your concubines, to look after.

2:3d

and let them be given beauty treatments.

- Hegai should give them perfume and ointment to rub on their skin to make them more beautiful.

2:3c-d

beauty treatments: The women were given ointments and perfumes to rub on their bodies to make their skin shine and look and smell beautiful.

Esther 2:5

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her

better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:5

Now there was at the citadel of Susa a Jewish man from the tribe of Benjamin named Mordecai son of Jair, the son of Shimei, the son of Kish.

- ¶ At that time there was a Jew named Mordecai living in the city of Susa. He was the son of Jair who was the son of Shimei who was the son of Kish who was from the tribe of Benjamin.

Now: This verse introduces Mordecai, one of the important characters in the story. If you have special ways of introducing characters in stories in your language, you should introduce Mordecai in that way here. The BSB has indicated this by using Now.

citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

from the tribe of Benjamin: All Jews traced their ancestors back to one of Jacob's 12 sons. Benjamin was Jacob's youngest son.

son of Jair, the son of Shimei, the son of Kish: Jair, Shimei and Kish were ancestors of Mordecai. Hebrew used the term "son of" in the more general sense of "descendant of," so some commentators think Shimei and Kish were famous ancestors of Mordecai who had lived many years before him. For example, Shimei is mentioned in 2 Samuel 16:5; and the father of King Saul, the first king of Israel, was called Kish (see 1 Samuel 9:1-2). GNT translates it in this way. However, this verse must be considered with the comments on 2:6 below, which seem to suggest that it is a literal "son of" which was meant here.

Esther 2:6

Section 2:1-18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:6

He had been carried into exile from Jerusalem by Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon among those taken captive with Jeconiah king of Judah.

- Many years before, when Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, had conquered the country of Judah and taken captive its king, Jehoiachin, and many other people from there, this Kish was among the people who had been taken away from the city of Jerusalem into Babylon.

He had been carried into exile: It is not clear to whom exactly this refers and the BSB is ambiguous. There are three main possibilities:

1. It refers to Kish, the great-grandfather of Mordecai. This seems to be the easiest way of understanding the Hebrew. (NJPS, CEV, GW)
2. It refers to Mordecai himself. However, if it were Mordecai himself who had been taken captive in 597 BC, he would be a very old man in 480 BC when this story takes place. So this seems rather unlikely. (GNT, REB)
3. It refers to Mordecai's family, but not necessarily Mordecai himself. No major English version follows this interpretation.

Both (1) and (2) are possible grammatically, but (1) is more probable since it is unlikely that Mordecai was already 120 years old in this story.

carried into exile: This means to be taken away or sent away from your own country and forced to live in another place.

taken captive with Jeconiah king of Judah: This refers to when the Babylonians defeated the people of the tribe of Judah in 597 BC. King Nebuchadnezzar then took the king of Judah and many of his people back with him to Babylon as captives. When the OT refers to "Judah" it usually includes the tribe of Benjamin as well.

Esther 2:7

Section 2:1-18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:7a

And Mordecai had brought up Hadassah (that is, Esther), the daughter of his uncle,

- Mordecai had reared Hadassah (called Esther), his cousin,

the daughter of his uncle: Literally "daughter of his paternal uncle." Esther's father and Mordecai's father were brothers. You should use the correct kinship term in your language for this sort of relative.

2:7b

because she did not have a father or mother.

- because both her father and mother were dead.

2:7d

The young woman was lovely in form and appearance,

- She had a beautiful face and figure.

2:7e

and when her father and mother had died, Mordecai had taken her in as his own daughter.

- After her parents had died, Mordecai had adopted her as his own daughter.

had taken her in as his own daughter: When Esther's parents died, Mordecai had adopted her and treated her as if she were his own daughter.

General Comment about 2:7

You may want to rearrange this verse in your language because of the repetition. GNT would be a helpful model to follow, if you wish to combine 2:7b and 2:7e:

He had a cousin, Esther, whose Hebrew name was Hadassah; she was a beautiful young woman, and had a good figure. At the death of her parents, Mordecai had adopted her and brought her up as his own daughter, (GNT)

Esther 2:8**Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen**

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:8a

When the king's command and edict had been proclaimed,

- ¶ After the king had given the order and it had been announced throughout the kingdom,

the king's command and edict: These two words are very similar in meaning. See 1:20a for edict.

2:8b

many young women gathered at the citadel of Susa under the care of Hegai.

- the king's officials brought many girls to the palace in Susa and gave them to Hegai to look after.

citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

General Comment about 2:8

As in 2:7, there is some repetition in this verse, so you may need to rearrange the verse as GNT has done:

When the king had issued his new proclamation and many young women were being brought to Susa, Esther was among them. She too was put in the royal palace in the care of Hegai, who had charge of the harem. (GNT)

2:8c

Esther was also taken to the palace and placed under the care of Hegai, the custodian of the women.

- Esther was among these girls, and along with them she was put into the care of Hegai, whose job was to look after the king's concubines.

Esther 2:9**Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen**

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:9a

And the young woman pleased him and obtained his favor,

- Hegai liked Esther, and she became a favorite with him.

2:9b

so he quickly provided her with beauty treatments and the special diet.

- At once he brought her ointments and perfumes to rub on her skin to make her more beautiful. He also provided good food for her to eat.

beauty treatments: See note on 2:3d.

2:9c

He assigned to her seven select maidservants from the palace

- He chose seven women among the king's servants to take care of her,

2:9d

and transferred her with them to the best place in the harem.

- and he put them all in the best place in the women's quarters.

2:9c-d

harem: See note on 2:3b.

Esther 2:10

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:10a

Esther did not reveal her people or her lineage,

- Now, Esther had not told anyone that she was a Jew or what family she came from,

2:10b

because Mordecai had instructed her not to do so.

- because before she went to the palace Mordecai had warned her not to do so.

2:10

It may be better in your language to reverse 2:10a and 2:10b. Then you could say something like:

Before she went to the palace, Mordecai had warned Esther not to tell anyone that she was a Jew or what family she came from, and she obeyed him.

Esther 2:11

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

2:11a

And every day Mordecai would walk back and forth in front of the court of the harem

- Every day Mordecai walked around near the part of the palace where the women lived.

harem: See note on 2:3b.

2:11b

to learn about Esther's welfare and what was happening to her.

- He went there to find out how Esther was doing and what was happening to her.
- He did this because he wanted to know how things were going for Esther and what was happening to her.

Esther 2:12

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:12–14

This paragraph contains background information. It gives general details of how the girls were prepared for the king.

2:12a

In the twelve months before her turn to go to King Xerxes,

- ¶ Each girl would go in turn and spend the night alone with King Xerxes,

to go to King Xerxes: This means to go to the king's private part of the palace and spend the night with him. You need to consider what is the polite way to express this in your language so your readers understand that she went to the king so that he could have sex with her.

2:12b

the harem regulation required each young woman to receive beauty treatments

- but first she had to spend a year in the harem using various ointments and perfumes to make herself more beautiful.

beauty treatments: See note on 2:3d.

2:12c

with oil of myrrh for six months, and then with perfumes and cosmetics for another six months.

- For the first six months, she used oil mixed with a sweet-smelling substance called myrrh. Then for the next six months she used other perfumes and ointments.

oil of myrrh: Myrrh is a resin which comes from certain trees. It has a pleasant smell and could be mixed with oil to make a perfume.

cosmetics: This is a general term for things like the powder and ointments women use to make themselves more beautiful.

Esther 2:13

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were

brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:12–14

This paragraph contains background information. It gives general details of how the girls were prepared for the king.

2:13a

When the young woman would go to the king,

- When the time came for the young woman to go and spend the night with the king,

2:13b

she was given whatever she requested to take with her from the harem to the king's palace.

- she was allowed to take anything she wanted with her from the harem: clothes, jewelry, or perfumes.

whatever she requested: This means any ornaments, jewelry, clothes, perfumes or cosmetics she wanted to make herself beautiful when she went to the king.

harem: See note on 2:3b.

Esther 2:14

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:12–14

This paragraph contains background information. It gives general details of how the girls were prepared for the king.

2:14a

She would go there in the evening, and in the morning she would return to a second harem

- She would go to the king in the evening and spend the night with him. The next morning she would leave the king's palace and go back to the harem, but this time to a different part.

a second harem: See note on 2:3b. Apparently, the harem was divided into two parts. The first part was for the girls who were waiting to go to the king; the second part was for those who had spent the night with him and so had become his concubines.

2:14b

under the care of Shaashgaz, the king's eunuch in charge of the concubines.

- The king's servant who looked after the women in this part of the harem was called Shaashgaz.

2:14c

She would not return to the king unless he delighted in her and summoned her by name.

- Normally each girl only went to the king once. However if the king liked her, he would ask for her by name and his servants would fetch her again.

Esther 2:15

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:15–18

In these verses, the story returns to Esther and Mordecai, the main characters in the story. If you have a way in your language to indicate this, you should use it here.

2:15a

Now Esther was the daughter of Abihail, the uncle from whom Mordecai had adopted her as his own daughter. And when it was her turn to go to the king,

- ¶ At last it was Esther's turn to go to the king. This Esther was the daughter of Abihail whom his brother's son Mordecai had adopted as his own child.

Esther was the daughter of Abihail, the uncle from whom Mordecai had adopted her as his own daughter:

You will need to study carefully the best way to include this information in your translation and where in the verse you should put it. Look at how different English versions have translated it. CEV even omits it completely, because the translators considered that Esther had already been introduced in 2:7.

2:15b

she did not ask for anything except what Hegai, the king's trusted official in charge of the harem, had advised.

- When the moment came for her to go to the king, she asked for only the things that Hegai advised her to take. Hegai was the servant who looked after the concubines.

- When the moment came for her to go to the king, she asked Hegai, who was the servant in charge of the harem, what she should take with her and then only took those things.

Hegai, the king's trusted official in charge of the harem: This is also repeated information and you need to decide whether you should repeat it in your translation.

harem: See note on 2:3b.

2:15c

And Esther found favor in the eyes of everyone who saw her.

- Everyone who saw her liked her.

Esther 2:16

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:15–18

In these verses, the story returns to Esther and Mordecai, the main characters in the story. If you have a way in your language to indicate this, you should use it here.

2:16

She was taken to King Xerxes in the royal palace in the tenth month, the month of Tebeth, in the seventh year of his reign.

- By this time, Xerxes had been king for seven years. It was during the tenth month, which is called Tebeth, that the servants took Esther to the king in his palace.

Tebeth: When the story took place, the Hebrew year began in the middle of March. So Tebeth, the tenth month, was from mid-December to mid-January. You could put this information in a footnote if you decide it is important for your readers.

Esther 2:17

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:15–18

In these verses, the story returns to Esther and Mordecai, the main characters in the story. If you have a way in your language to indicate this, you should use it here.

2:17a

And the king loved Esther more than all the other women,

- When Esther went to the king, he found her more attractive than any of the young women who had already been to him.

The reference to the length of the king's reign at the end of 2:16 has interrupted the story about Esther, so in order to resume the story, you may need to repeat the fact that Esther went to the king. See the Display.

2:17b

and she found grace and favor in his sight more than all of the other virgins.

- She pleased him and he liked her more than the others.

2:17c

So he placed the royal crown upon her head

- So he took a crown and put it on Esther's head

royal crown: See note on 1:11a.

2:17d

and made her queen in place of Vashti.

- and so made her queen in place of Vashti.

Esther 2:18

Section 2:1–18: The king chose a new queen

Some time later the king decided to choose a new queen to replace Vashti. Many beautiful girls were brought to the palace and Esther was among them. When her turn came to go to the king, he liked her better than any other girl, so he chose her to be his new queen.

Paragraph 2:15–18

In these verses, the story returns to Esther and Mordecai, the main characters in the story. If you have a way in your language to indicate this, you should use it here.

2:18a

Then the king held a great banquet, Esther's banquet, for all his officials and servants.

- To celebrate this he gave a big feast to honor Esther, and he invited all his officials and the other important men to come to it.

officials and servants: See notes on 1:3a.

2:18b**He proclaimed a tax holiday in the provinces**

- He also said that all the people in his kingdom could rest from their work to celebrate Esther becoming queen.

tax holiday: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as holiday is more literally “causing to rest.” There are two main ways that English versions translate this word:

1. It refers to any type of holiday. (NIV, GNT, NCV, CEV)
2. It refers to a period of not paying taxes, something that kings of that time sometimes did to celebrate special events. (BSB, NJPS, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option.

2:18c**and gave gifts worthy of the king’s bounty.**

- He also told his servants to distribute presents among the people to demonstrate his generosity.
- Also he gave many good things to people in the way that is fitting for a king.

worthy of the king’s bounty: This means that the king did it in a way which displayed his generosity. He did it in the way people expected a king to behave.

Esther 2:19**Section 2:19–23: Mordecai discovered a plot against the king**

These verses describe an event which will be very important later in the story. Two of the king’s servants were angry with the king and plotted to kill him. Mordecai heard about the plot and told Esther, who in turn told the king. The two servants were executed, and the event was written in the records of the kingdom.

2:19a**When the virgins were assembled a second time,**

- ¶ After some time, the king’s officials gathered together the group of virgins again.

When the virgins were assembled a second time: It is not known who this group of virgins was or why they were gathered together after Esther had already been chosen to be queen. The various interpretations are:

1. It refers to the previous group of virgins first mentioned in 2:8. (BSB, KJV, NIV, RSV, NJPS, NASB, GW; Keil & Delitzsch, p.341).
2. It refers to the gathering of another group of virgins. (LB; Bush, p.372)
3. It should be omitted. (LXX, REB, GNT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation, which is the majority view.

2:19b**Mordecai was sitting at the king’s gate.**

- By this time, Mordecai had become one of the officials working for the king.

Mordecai was sitting at the king’s gate: This can be understood in two different ways:

1. It is meant figuratively. The gate of the king’s palace was where important business took place, so to say that Mordecai was sitting at the king’s gate means that he was an important government official. (GNT, CEV)
2. It should be understood literally. Once Esther became queen, Mordecai would spend time at the palace entrance, hoping to get news of how Esther was. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NCV, NJPS, GW)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation because it is the most logical one in the context.

Esther 2:21**Section 2:19–23: Mordecai discovered a plot against the king**

These verses describe an event which will be very important later in the story. Two of the king’s servants were angry with the king and plotted to kill him. Mordecai heard about the plot and told Esther, who in turn told the king. The two servants were executed, and the event was written in the records of the kingdom.

2:21a**In those days, while Mordecai was sitting at the king’s gate,**

- ¶ One day Mordecai was doing his work at the palace entrance.

the king’s gate: See note on 2:19b.

2:21b**Bigthana and Teresh, two of the king’s eunuchs who guarded the entrance, grew angry and conspired to assassinate King Xerxes.**

- Two of the king’s servants who guarded the palace plotted to kill the king, because they were angry with him. Their names were Bigthana and Teresh.
- Bigthana and Teresh, two of the servants whose job was to guard the palace entrance, got angry with the king and started to discuss and plan how they could kill him.

who guarded the entrance: They guarded the entrance to the palace, and therefore the palace itself.

Esther 2:23

Section 2:19–23: Mordecai discovered a plot against the king

These verses describe an event which will be very important later in the story. Two of the king's servants were angry with the king and plotted to kill him. Mordecai heard about the plot and told Esther, who in turn told the king. The two servants were executed, and the event was written in the records of the kingdom.

2:23a

After the report had been investigated and verified,

- The king sent people to investigate the story and they found out that it was true.

2:23b

both officials were hanged on the gallows.

- So, on the king's orders, they seized the two servants and they hung them on wooden poles, and so they died.

hanged on the gallows: In the Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “hanged on a tree.” It is possible that Xerxes had these men executed by impaling them on a piece of wood, rather than hanging them by a rope. However, the Hebrew text uses the verb “to hang,” and this is how most English versions translate it. It is recommended that you follow the majority of English translations.

2:23c

And all this was recorded in the Book of the Chronicles in the presence of the king.

- Then, the king ordered that one of his secretaries should write, as he watched, all that had happened in the book where they recorded the important things that happened in the kingdom.

Book of the Chronicles: This book recorded all the important happenings in the Persian Empire.

Esther 3:1

Section 3:1–6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:1a

After these events, King Xerxes honored Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite,

- ¶ Some years later, King Xerxes greatly honored a man called Haman, son of Hammedatha, a descendant of Agag.

After these events: The text doesn't state an exact time here, but it was probably about four years after Esther had become queen.

honored: No reason is given why the king suddenly decided to honor Haman.

Agagite: Agag was the name of the king of the Amalekites whom King Saul conquered and took prisoner and whom Samuel cut in pieces (1 Samuel 15:8, 33). It may be that Haman was descended from this king.

3:1b

elevating him to a position above all the princes who were with him.

- He gave him a more important job than before and made him chief over all the other officials in his kingdom.
- He promoted him and made him more important than all the other officials.

elevating him: This means that Xerxes promoted Haman and gave him a more important position in his government than he had had before.

princes: See note on 1:3b.

Esther 3:2

Section 3:1–6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:2a

All the royal servants at the king's gate bowed down and paid homage to Haman,

- All the officials who worked at the palace gate knelt down and bowed their heads to the ground in front of Haman to show their respect

royal servants: See note on “official” at 1:3a.

at the king's gate: See note on 2:19b.

bowed down: Literally “prostrate oneself,” that is, a person knelt on the ground and bent forward until his head touched the ground. It was a common way of showing respect to someone very important. If such actions in your culture do not mean showing respect, you will have to add this implicit information or state the information in a footnote.

3:2b

because the king had commanded that this be done for him.

- just as the king had ordered them to do.

3:2c

But Mordecai would not bow down or pay homage.

- But Mordecai refused to do this.

3:2b-c

The text does not explain why Mordecai refused to bow down. The only clue given is 3:4, where he seems to have told the other servants that it was because he was a Jew. Perhaps he refused to bow down because he thought this would be disobeying the second commandment (Exodus 20:4).

Esther 3:3

Section 3:1-6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:3a

Then the royal servants at the king's gate asked Mordecai,

- Then/So the other officials who worked at the palace gate asked Mordecai,

royal servants: See note on “officials” at 1:3a.

at the king's gate: See note on 2:19b.

3:3b

“Why do you disobey the command of the king?”

- “Why do you refuse to do what the king has ordered?”

Esther 3:4

Section 3:1-6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest

position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:4a

Day after day they warned him, but he would not comply.

- Each day they questioned him like this, but he would not change the way he acted.

3:4b

So they reported it to Haman to see whether Mordecai's behavior would be tolerated, since he had told them he was a Jew.

- Instead, he replied that he refused to bow down, because he was a Jew. When they heard this, they told Haman what Mordecai had said because they wanted to see whether Haman would allow Mordecai to behave in this way.

3:4

There are several different ways to rearrange this verse and connect the various phrases. The Display follows GNT. Both CEV and NCV have other models you could follow.

since he had told them he was a Jew: See note on 3:2c.

Esther 3:5

Section 3:1-6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:5

When Haman saw that Mordecai would not bow down or pay him homage, he was filled with rage.

- When Haman saw that Mordecai refused to kneel or bow his head to the ground to show him respect, he became very angry.

bow down: See note on 3:2a.

Esther 3:6

Section 3:1–6: Haman became angry with Mordecai

The next event in the story was that the king promoted one of his officials called Haman to the highest position in the land, next to the king himself. The king ordered all his servants to bow down to Haman in respect to him, but Mordecai refused to do this because he was a Jew. When Haman heard about this, he was angry and planned to destroy all the Jews in the empire. He cast lots to find out the best day to choose for killing the Jews.

3:6a

And when he learned the identity of Mordecai's people, he scorned the notion of laying hands on Mordecai alone.

- And then when he learned that Mordecai was a Jew, he decided that to kill only Mordecai was not enough.

the identity of Mordecai's people: That is, that they were Jews. You may need to state this information explicitly here.

3:6b

Instead, he sought to destroy all of Mordecai's people, the Jews, throughout the kingdom of Xerxes.

- Instead he decided to find a way to kill along with Mordecai, all the other Jews throughout the whole kingdom of Xerxes.

Esther 3:7

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:7a

In the twelfth year of King Xerxes, in the first month, the month of Nisan,

- ¶ It was now the twelfth year that Xerxes was king. During the first month of that year, the month called Nisan,

Nisan: See the note about Tebeth in 2:16. The month of Nisan was mid-March to mid-April.

3:7b

the Pur (that is, the lot) was cast before Haman

- Haman ordered the astrologers to cast lots while he was watching. This lot was also called “pur.”

3:7c

to determine a day and month.

- They did this because Haman wanted to know the best day and the best month to do what he had planned.

3:7b–c

the Pur (that is, the lot) was cast before Haman: The verse does not say who cast the Pur. The Hebrew text says “he cast...” but this cannot refer to Haman, because the verse contains the phrase “in the presence of Haman.” Because of this, many versions make this phrase passive and say, “the Pur was cast.” The Pur, or the lot, were probably cast by an astrologer or another person who claimed to be able to predict the future. If your language has no passive, you could say: “Haman ordered the people to cast the Pur (that is, the lot).”

Pur: This was another word for “lot.” This word is important because the Jews used the plural of this word, purim, as the name of the festival they would later hold to celebrate their victory over their enemies (see 9:20–32).

lot: No one knows exactly how Persians cast lots. One possible method could have been that someone threw a group of small objects like stones or sticks in the air. After they fell to the ground, this person would study the pattern they made and from it answer the question being asked.

3:7d

And the lot fell on the twelfth month, the month of Adar.

- After they had cast the lots, they decided that the best time would be the twelfth month which is called Adar.

Adar: See the note about Tebeth in 2:16. The month of Adar was mid-February to mid-March.

Esther 3:8

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:8a**Then Haman informed King Xerxes,**

- Then Haman went to the king, and said to him,

3:8b**“There is a certain people scattered and dispersed among the peoples of every province of your kingdom. Their laws are different from everyone else’s,**

- “Your Majesty, there is a certain race of people living everywhere throughout your kingdom. They live among the other races, but their customs are not like those of any other race in your kingdom.

3:8a-b

Haman was addressing the king. Some Bible versions use an honorific title to show that Haman was addressing the king. You again need to decide whether or not to use a term like “Your Majesty” and whether Haman should address the king as “you” or not.

3:8c**and they do not obey the king’s laws.**

- They continually disobey your laws.

3:8d**So it is not in the king’s best interest to tolerate them.**

- It is of no advantage to you to allow them to continue to live in your kingdom.
- Things would be better for you if you did not allow them to live in your kingdom any longer.

3:8c-d

So it is not in the king’s best interest to tolerate them: This can also be translated in a negative form. For example, the CEV has:

We would be better off to get rid of them!

Esther 3:9**Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews**

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:9a**If it pleases the king, let a decree be issued to destroy them,**

- So, if it pleases you, tell your officials to send out an order to kill them.
- So, if this seems like a good idea to you, make a command which says that people have your permission to kill them.

If it pleases the king: See note on 1:19a.**decree:** See note on 1:19a.**3:9b****and I will deposit ten thousand talents of silver into the royal treasury to pay those who carry it out.”**

- If you do this, I will bring 750,000 pounds of silver and give it to the officials who look after your wealth and they can store it with the rest of your riches.”

ten thousand talents of silver: This was an enormous amount of money. A talent weighed 75 pounds (34 kilograms). So the total amount was 750,000 pounds of silver (340,000 kilograms). This equals 335 British tons, 375 American tons and 340 metric tonnes. You should choose whichever measure is normally used in your area. However the most important thing to communicate is that Haman was promising a huge amount of money. If you use footnotes in your translation, you could put this information there. The text does not explain where Haman expected to get all this money. He may have been very wealthy already, or he may have expected to get the wealth of the Jews who would be killed.

the royal treasury: This refers to the place where all the king’s wealth was stored.

those who carry it out: Literally “the doers of the work.” This may refer to:

1. the officials who ran the government of the empire, as the same expression clearly does in 9:3. Here it would refer especially to those who looked after the king’s financial matters. The order of the Hebrew and the reference to the “royal treasury” also suggest that this is the best interpretation. (RSV, GNT, NCV, CEV, NJPS, GW, REB, NLT, JB)
2. the men who would carry out the order to destroy all the Jews. (BSB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option 1. The Display follows the NCV.

Esther 3:10**Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews**

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed.

Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:10a

So the king removed the signet ring from his finger

- When the king heard this plan, he removed his ring from his finger

the signet ring: This was a ring that the king wore on his finger which he used to press on the wax which sealed his letters. This would show that the document had been written with the king's authority and so its message should be obeyed. By giving Haman this ring, the king authorized him to treat the Jews in any way he wished.

3:10b

and gave it to Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite, the enemy of the Jews.

- and gave it to Haman, who hated the Jews. (Haman was the son of Hammedatha, and a descendant of Agag.)

Agagite: See note on 3:1a.

Esther 3:12

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:12a

On the thirteenth day of the first month, the royal scribes were summoned

- ¶ So on the thirteenth day in the first month, Haman told the people who wrote letters for the king to come to him.

royal scribes: These were men whose job was to write the letters and documents the king told them to write.

3:12b

and the order was written exactly as Haman commanded the royal satraps, the governors of each province, and the officials of each people,

- They wrote down all that Haman told them to write. Then they sent these documents to the king's offi-

cials, the governors of each province and the chiefs of each race,

satraps: This is another word for government officials.

officials: This is the same word as 1:3a, but here it is best translated as “leaders” or “chiefs.”

3:12c

in the script of each province and the language of every people.

- according to the language and way of writing of the different races in the different areas of the kingdom.

script: See note on 1:22b.

3:12d

It was written in the name of King Xerxes

- The secretaries wrote these documents with the authority of King Xerxes himself.

in the name of King Xerxes: This means that they wrote the letters with the king's full authority.

3:12e

and sealed with the royal signet ring.

- Then they sealed them with wax and stamped the wax with the king's own ring.

sealed with the royal signet ring: When people finished writing a document, they then rolled it up and covered the end of the paper with wax. The king then stamped it with his seal, that is, he pressed the wax with the special ring on one of his fingers. This made a design on the wax and showed that the letter was authorized by the king.

Esther 3:13

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:13a

And the letters were sent by couriers to each of the royal provinces

- Then Haman sent messengers everywhere in the kingdom to deliver the documents.

And the letters: See note on 1:22a.

couriers: These were people whose job was to travel throughout the empire delivering important messages.

3:13b

with the order to destroy, kill, and annihilate all the Jews—young and old, women and children—

- The documents contained the following order: “You^(plur) must annihilate the Jews. Kill every one of them, whether they are young or old. Don’t even spare the women or the children.

destroy, kill, and annihilate: These three words are similar in meaning and when used together cause the language to be very strong. The Display shows one way of translating this.

3:13c

and to plunder their possessions

- Then you^(plur) can keep the things that belonged to them for yourselves.”

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

3:13d

on a single day, the thirteenth day of Adar, the twelfth month.

- The day chosen for this event is the thirteenth day of Adar, the twelfth month. On that one day, you^(plur) must kill them all.

plunder their possessions: This means to take and keep the belongings of the people they had killed.

Esther 3:14

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:14a

A copy of the text of the edict was to be issued in every province and published to all the people,

- When the messengers arrived in each province with the documents, they told the officials there to read the new law to the people. They had to explain the words of the document to the people of each race,
- In each region, when the officials received their copy of the document, they were ordered to make sure everyone knew what the new law was

edict: See note on 1:20a.

was to be issued: The edict was to be made public, so that everybody would know about it and know that it was a law that must be obeyed. Probably when the document arrived in each town, officials would go to different parts of the area and read it aloud. It is also possible (though less likely) that it was displayed in a public place for people to read.

3:14b

so that they would be ready on that day.

- so that everyone would be prepared to kill the Jews on that day.

Esther 3:15

Section 3:7–15: Haman plotted to kill the Jews

Haman went to the king and told him that the Jews in the empire did not obey the laws of the land, and so they all should be killed. The king authorized him to write an order saying that the Jews should be killed. Haman caused the order to be sent out everywhere in the kingdom on the thirteenth day of the first month of the next year. The order told the public to be ready to attack the Jews on the thirteenth day of the twelfth month.

3:15a

The couriers left, spurred on by the king’s command,

- Since it was the king who had given the order, the messengers left without delay

The couriers: See note on 3:13a.

spurred on by the king’s command: Since the king himself authorized the order, it was especially important, so it had to be distributed quickly. The verb which the BSB translates spurred on means “to drive, hasten.”

3:15b

and the edict was issued in the citadel of Susa.

- while other officials read the document to the people in the city of Susa.
- while other officials announced the law to the people in the city of Susa.

the edict: See note on 1:20a.

the citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

3:15c

Then the king and Haman sat down to drink, but the city of Susa was in confusion.

- When the people of Susa heard about the king’s order, they were bewildered/fearful; but at that same

time the king and Haman were sitting together drinking wine.

but: The action of the king and Haman, sitting calmly drinking, contrasts very strongly with the confusion among the people of the city.

the city of Susa: This refers to the people living in the city.

in confusion: The text does not explain why the people were in confusion. Most likely it was because they did not understand the reason for the edict and so were upset and confused. Another possibility is that it referred only to the Jews in the city, who were naturally upset because of the content of the edict.

Esther 4:1

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:1a

When Mordecai learned of all that had happened,

- ¶ When Mordecai heard about all that had happened,

4:1b

he tore his clothes, put on sackcloth and ashes,

- he was very sad. So he tore his clothes and instead dressed himself in rough cloth and sprinkled ashes on his head.

tore his clothes: This was one way Jews showed that something terrible had happened to them.

put on sackcloth: Sackcloth was coarse cloth usually made from goat's hair and black in color. The Jews dressed in sackcloth to mourn for the dead or at times of great personal or national disaster.

put on...ashes: This was yet another way to show deep grief. A person would usually sprinkle the ashes on his head.

You may need to find some way of informing your readers that all these actions were a sign of being

very unhappy about something. The Display shows one way. Another way would be to explain the actions in a footnote.

4:1c

and went out into the middle of the city, wailing loudly and bitterly.

- Dressed like this, he walked through the city, crying and wailing loudly.

wailing loudly and bitterly: Use the natural expression in your language for expressing great sorrow.

Esther 4:2

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:2a

But he went only as far as the king's gate,

- However, when he arrived at the palace entrance, he went no further,

the king's gate: See note on 2:19b. Here however it refers literally to the palace entrance.

4:2b

because the law prohibited anyone wearing sackcloth from entering that gate.

- because no person who was wearing rough cloth was allowed to go inside.

Esther 4:3

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally

agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:3a

In every province to which the king's command and edict came,

- In every province, wherever the messengers with the king's order arrived,
- Everywhere in the kingdom, where people learned about the law which the king had made,

king's command and edict: See note on 2:8a.

4:3b

there was great mourning among the Jews. They fasted, wept, and lamented,

- the Jews were very distressed. They refused to eat food, they wept and they lamented.

They fasted: When people fasted, they chose not to eat food for a chosen length of time. They also usually prayed to God. In the book of Esther there is a sharp contrast between the king and his men who feasted (see 3:15), and the Jews who fasted (see 4:3, 16).

4:3c

and many lay in sackcloth and ashes.

- Because of their grief many people spread ashes and rough cloth on the ground and lay on top of them.

many lay in sackcloth and ashes: Literally “sackcloth and ashes were spread to many.” This phrase is ambiguous in many English versions. There are three possibilities:

1. lay in sackcloth and ashes means that people spread ashes on the ground, put sackcloth on top of the ashes, and then they lay on the sackcloth. For example, the NCV has:

many of them lay down on rough cloth and ashes (BSB, NCV, REB)

1. The expression means to “put on,” in the same way as Mordecai did in 4:1b. So the people acted in the same way as Mordecai. For example, the GW has:

Many put on sackcloth and ashes (GW)

1. lay in sackcloth means to lie down wearing sackcloth. However lay in...ashes means to lie down on ashes. For example, the GNT has:

most of them put on sackcloth and lay in ashes (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option.

Esther 4:4

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:4a

When Esther's maidens and eunuchs came and told her about Mordecai, the queen was overcome with distress.

- ¶ Some of the women who served Esther and the men who looked after her came and told her what Mordecai was doing. When she heard this, she was very upset.

Esther's maidens and eunuchs: These were Esther's female and male servants. For more on “eunuch” see the note on 1:10b.

4:4b

She sent clothes for Mordecai to wear instead of his sackcloth, but he would not accept them.

- She gave some good clothes to some of her servants and sent them with them to Mordecai. She told them to tell him that he should take off his rough cloth and wear these instead. But Mordecai refused.

Esther 4:6

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally

agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:6

So Hathach went out to Mordecai in the city square in front of the king's gate,

- ¶ So Hathach went out of the palace and found Mordecai in the open area beside the palace entrance.

the city square: This was an open area where there were no buildings.

the king's gate: See note on 4:2a. Here too it refers literally to the palace entrance.

Esther 4:7

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:7a

and Mordecai told him all that had happened to him,

- Mordecai told him about all the things that had happened to him.

4:7b

including the exact amount of money that Haman had promised to pay into the royal treasury in order to destroy the Jews.

- He even told him exactly how much money Haman had said that he would add to the riches of the king, if the king allowed people to kill the Jews.
- He even told him exactly how much money Haman had offered the king if he would order the destruction of the Jews.

the royal treasury: See note on 3:9b.

Esther 4:8

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to

mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:8a

Mordecai also gave Hathach a copy of the written decree issued in Susa for the destruction of the Jews,

- He also gave him a copy of the document which the messengers had read in the city of Susa and which said that people could kill the Jews.
- He also gave him one of the documents which the king's messengers had delivered to Susa and which told the people that they were to kill the Jews,

a copy of the written decree issued in Susa for the destruction of the Jews: That is, a copy of the document which ordered people to kill the Jews.

4:8b

to show and explain to Esther,

- He said to him, "Go show it to Esther and explain it to her."
- so that he could show/give it to Esther and explain it to her.

4:8c

urging her to approach the king, implore his favor, and plead before him for her people.

- He added, "Tell Esther that she must go to see the king and beg him to have mercy on the Jews, her own race."
- He also told him to persuade her to go and see the king personally so that she could beg him not to allow the people to kill the Jews, her own people.

for her people: Mordecai was reminding Esther that she too was a Jew. If there is no distinction between "his" and "her" in your language, you must take care that it is referring clearly to Esther's people, not the king's or Hathach's.

Esther 4:11

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but

he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:11a

“All the royal officials and the people of the king’s provinces know that one law applies to every man or woman who approaches the king in the inner court without being summoned—that he be put to death.

- “Everyone, whether one of the king’s officials or an ordinary person in any part of the kingdom knows the law. It says that if anyone, whether man or woman, goes into the room in the middle of the palace where the king usually is without a special invitation from him, the king will tell his servants to kill that person.

All the royal officials and the people of the king’s provinces: That is, everyone throughout the kingdom.

royal officials: See note on 1:3a.

the inner court: This was the part of the palace where the king met with people.

without being summoned: That is, without the king inviting them to come.

4:11b

Only if the king extends the gold scepter may that person live.

- The only escape is if the king holds out his gold stick to the person to show that he should not die.
- The only way that this will not happen is if the king holds out his gold stick to the person. Then he will not die.

the gold scepter: This was the special stick that the king often held in his hand. It indicated the king’s authority to rule. It was made of gold.

4:11c

But I have not been summoned to appear before the king for the past thirty days.”

- As for me, it is thirty days since the last time the king invited me to go to him.”

Esther 4:14

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to

mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:14a

For if you remain silent at this time, relief and deliverance for the Jews will arise from another place,

- If you refuse to beg the king to save the Jews now, someone else will rescue the Jews.

from another place: There are two different possibilities to interpret where the other place where help will come from:

1. The help will come from someone else. For example, the NCV has:

someone else will come to help and save the Jewish people (BSB, NCV, NIV, NLT, ESV)

1. The help will come from God. For example, the GNT has:

help will come from heaven

It is recommended that you follow the first option, there is nothing in the text to suggest Mordecai was referring to God.

4:14b

but you and your father’s house will perish.

- But you and your family will die.
- But our whole family, including you, will die.

you and your father’s house: The CEV includes Mordecai with those who would be saved in 4:14a (“we will somehow get help”). But Mordecai was part of Esther’s father’s family, so he was surely including himself in those who would die if Esther didn’t speak to the king.

4:14c

And who knows if perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?”

- Perhaps the reason you became queen was to prevent such a bad thing as this from happening.”

you have come to the kingdom: That is, “you have become queen.”

for such a time as this: That is, that Esther had been made queen at this particular time in order to be able to prevent the killing of the Jews.

Esther 4:16

Section 4:1–17: Mordecai asked Esther to beg the king to save the Jews

When Mordecai heard about the order to kill the Jews, he dressed in the sort of clothes he would wear to mourn someone who had died and walked around the city weeping loudly. Esther sent him other clothes but he refused to wear them. She then sent a messenger to find out why he was behaving in this way. Mordecai gave the messenger a copy of the decree to show to Esther, and he pleaded with her to go and ask the king not to destroy the Jews. Esther hesitated, but finally agreed, although it was dangerous for her to approach the king in this way and she might be killed.

4:16a

“Go and assemble all the Jews who can be found in Susa, and fast for me.

- “Assemble all the Jews who live in Susa. Then you^(plur) all must decide not to eat, but instead pray for me.

Go: The Hebrew word *leḵ* literally means “go.” However, when this word precedes another command, it usually makes the second command more emphatic and so should not be translated literally. In English, “go” can be used in the same way as it is in Hebrew, but if in your language it would mean that Esther was telling Mordecai to go somewhere, you should choose one of the following options:

- If there is some other way of emphasizing a command in your language, use that to emphasize the commands “assemble” and “fast,” and omit “go.”
- Just omit “go,” as the CEV has done.

fast for me: See note on 4:3b. Here, because the text says fast for me, it is very probable that Esther wanted the people, while they fasted, to pray to God to help her.

4:16b

Do not eat or drink for three days, night or day,

- For three days and three nights do not eat or drink anything.

4:16c

and I and my maidens will fast as you do.

- I and the women who serve me will do the same.

4:16d

After that, I will go to the king, even though it is against the law. And if I perish, I perish!”

- After that, I will go to see/talk to the king, even though I am disobeying his law. If he orders his servants to kill me, I am willing to die.”

Esther 5:1

Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:1a

On the third day, Esther put on her royal attire

- ¶ After Esther had refused food for two days, the next day she put on clothes which showed that she was queen.

On the third day: That is, on the last day of the fast.

5:1b

and stood in the inner court of the palace across from the king’s quarters.

- Then she went into the middle part of the palace. This area was near the room where the king’s special chair was.

the king’s quarters: The word translated “quarters” is literally “house.” The expression “house of the king” can mean the whole palace, but here it probably refers to the room where the king would sit on his throne to receive visitors.

5:1c

The king was sitting on his royal throne in the royal courtroom, facing the entrance.

- At the moment when she entered the area, the king was sitting on his special chair, looking toward the entrance to the room.

his royal throne: A throne is the special chair a king or queen sits on, especially when greeting visitors or during other special occasions. It may have been made of, or decorated with, gold.

Esther 5:2

Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:2a

As soon as the king saw Queen Esther standing in the court, she found favor in his sight.

- When he saw the queen, Esther, standing outside the room, he was pleased to see her.

5:2b

The king extended the gold scepter in his hand toward Esther,

- So he stretched out the gold stick he was holding to her to show her that he allowed her to approach him.

the gold scepter: See note on 4:11b.

5:2c

and she approached and touched the tip of the scepter.

- So Esther entered the room, went toward the king and touched the end of the stick.

touched the tip of the scepter: The text does not describe whether Esther touched the scepter with her hand or her lips (that is, she kissed it; see Keil-Delitzsch, p. 355). If you can use a general verb, like the English versions, and not specify how she touched the scepter, you should do so. If it is necessary in your language to say how she touched the scepter, it is recommended that you say “with her hand,” since this is the most natural meaning of the Hebrew verb.

Esther 5:3**Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king**

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:3a

“What is it, Queen Esther?” the king inquired. “What is your request?”

- Then the king asked her, “Queen Esther, what’s the matter? What do you want to ask me?”

Queen Esther: You need to decide the best way for King Xerxes to address Esther in your language. In Hebrew, he uses her title “queen” and her name “Esther.” Maybe it would be better for you just to use her name, or just her title or even to not use either one.

5:3b

Even up to half the kingdom, it will be given to you.”

- I will give you whatever you ask. If you wish it, I will even divide my kingdom and give you one half.”

Esther 5:4**Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king**

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:4a

“If it pleases the king,” Esther replied,

- Esther replied, “Your Majesty, if you agree,

If it pleases the king: See note on 1:19a. Here you need to decide if Esther as queen should address Xerxes differently than the male servants did.

5:4b

“may the king and Haman come today to the banquet I have prepared for the king.”

- please come to me today. I have caused a feast to be prepared for you. Bring Haman with you.”

the banquet I have prepared for the king: Because Esther is referring to the king in the third person, “him” refers to the king, not Haman. It is unlikely that Esther cooked the food for the banquet herself, but rather that she ordered her servants to do so. You may need to state this explicitly in your translation.

banquet: See note on 1:9.

Esther 5:5**Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king**

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:5a

“Hurry,” commanded the king, “and bring Haman, so we can do as Esther has requested.”

- ¶ The king agreed to do what Esther wanted, and he sent someone immediately to fetch Haman so that they^(dual) could go to Esther’s feast.
- So the king turned to one of his servants and said, “Go and bring Haman here at once so that we^(dual excl) can go together to the queen’s feast.”

Notice that the king was no longer talking to Esther, but to one of his servants. The Display shows a couple of ways to state this explicitly.

Esther: The king here refers to Esther by her name. If this would be inappropriate or too familiar in your language, you may have to say “the queen” instead.

5:5b

So the king and Haman went to the banquet that Esther had prepared.

- When Haman arrived, both he and the king went to Esther to eat the feast she had caused to be prepared.

the banquet that Esther had prepared: See note on 5:4b.

banquet: See note on 1:9.

Esther 5:6

Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:6a

And as they drank their wine, the king said to Esther, “What is your petition? It will be given to you.”

- ¶ At the moment when they were drinking wine, the king asked Esther once more, “What do you want to ask me? I will give you whatever you want.”

And as they drank their wine: This probably refers to a special part of the feast, after they had finished eating.

5:6b

What is your request? Even up to half the kingdom, it will be fulfilled.”

- What do you want me to give you? If you ask me to, I will even divide my kingdom and give you one half.”

What is your request?: This means the same as “What is your petition?” in 5:6a. If you do not have two ways of saying this in your language, you may wish to combine the two phrases, as in the CEV:

What can I do for you? Just ask, and I will give you as much as half my kingdom.

Esther 5:7

Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:7

Esther replied, “This is my petition and my request:

- Esther replied, “This is what I want:

This is my petition and my request: As mentioned in the note on 5:6b, these words mean the same thing.

Esther 5:8

Section 5:1–8: Esther went to talk to the king

After Esther had finished fasting, she went to the inner rooms of the palace. The king was pleased to see her and promised to grant any request she might make. So she asked that the king and Haman should come and eat a special meal that she would get her servants to prepare for them. The king agreed.

5:8a

If I have found favor in the sight of the king, and if it pleases the king to grant my petition and fulfill my request,

- if you are pleased with me and want to do what I ask and give me what I want,

if it pleases the king: See note on 1:19a.

5:8b

may the king and Haman come tomorrow to the banquet I will prepare for them.

- then come here again tomorrow with Haman to eat the feast that I will cause to be prepared for you^(plur).

banquet: See note on 1:9.

5:8c

Then I will answer the king’s question.”

- At that time I will tell you what I want.”

Esther 5:9

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends’ advice, he decided to kill him.

5:9a

That day Haman went out full of joy and glad of heart.

- ¶ After the feast Haman left Esther's banquet in a happy mood. He was overjoyed.

full of joy and glad of heart: This means extremely pleased. Try to find an idiom or vivid expression in your language to express this meaning.

5:9b

At the king's gate, however, he saw Mordecai,

- But his mood changed when he arrived at the palace entrance and saw Mordecai.

the king's gate: See note at 2:19b. Again, here this refers literally to the entrance to the king's palace.

5:9c

who did not rise or tremble in fear at his presence.

- Once more Mordecai did not stand up or show any other sign of respect for him.

did not rise or tremble in fear: In 3:2, Mordecai had refused to bow down to Haman. Here he refuses to show respect by standing up or to appear to be afraid. The word translated "fear" can also mean "respect."

5:9d

And Haman was filled with rage toward Mordecai.

- This made him very angry with Mordecai.

Esther 5:10

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends' advice, he decided to kill him.

5:10a

Nevertheless, Haman restrained himself and went home.

- However Haman stopped himself from showing how angry he was and went home.

restrained himself: This means that Haman did not show his anger by saying or doing anything at that time.

5:10b

And calling for his friends and his wife Zeresh,

- When he arrived home, he sent someone to fetch his friends and also told his wife, whose name was Zeresh, to come and listen.

Esther 5:11

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends' advice, he decided to kill him.

5:11a

Haman recounted to them his glorious wealth, his many sons,

- When they were all together, he began reminding them how very rich he was, and about how many sons he had,

his many sons: It was considered a blessing to have many sons, and Haman had ten (see 9:10).

5:11b

and all the ways the king had honored

- and about all the ways that the king had made him important,
- he also told them about all the ways the king had made him important

the king had honored and promoted him: Literally "the king had made him great."

5:11c

and promoted him over the other officials and servants.

- and how he had given him a position above all the other important men in the kingdom.
- and promoted him instead of his other officials.

promoted: See note on 3:1b.

officials and servants: See note on 1:3a.

Esther 5:12

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends' advice, he decided to kill him.

5:12a

"What is more," Haman added, "Queen Esther invited no one but me to join the king at the banquet she prepared,

- Then he continued, "There is something better than all that. Today when Esther, the queen, invited the

king to eat a feast, I was the only other person she invited.

Notice that in the English versions, this verse is in direct speech, whereas 5:11 was indirect. You need to decide if it is possible in your language to keep these verses in this way or whether it would be better to treat both verses in the same way.

What is more: This translates a Hebrew word which means that what follows is even greater than what was before. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

And that's not all (NIV)

banquet: See note on 1:9.

5:12b

and I am invited back tomorrow along with the king.

- And she has invited me as well as the king to another feast tomorrow.

I am invited back tomorrow along with the king: The emphasis is on the word “me” here. Haman was saying that he was such an important man in the kingdom that he was the only other person besides the king who was invited to the queen's feast.

Esther 5:13

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends' advice, he decided to kill him.

5:13

Yet none of this satisfies me as long as I see Mordecai the Jew sitting at the king's gate.”

- But when I keep seeing that Jew called Mordecai sitting at the palace entrance, none of these things give me any joy.”
- But all these things are not enough to keep me happy while I can still see day after day that Jew Mordecai sitting at the palace entrance.”

the king's gate: See note on 5:9b. Again, here this refers literally to the entrance to the king's palace.

Esther 5:14

Section 5:9–14: Haman planned to kill Mordecai

Haman was delighted that Esther had invited him to eat with the king again, since it was a great honor. But on his way home, he became angry when Mordecai once more refused to show him the respect he thought he was owed, and, taking his friends' advice, he decided to kill him.

5:14a

His wife Zeresh and all his friends told him,

- When he had finished speaking, his wife Zeresh and all his friends said to him,

5:14b

“Have them build a gallows fifty cubits high, and ask the king in the morning to have Mordecai hanged on it.

- “Get someone to prepare a tall wooden pole, 25 meters high. Then tomorrow morning ask the king to order his servants to hang Mordecai on it and so he will die.

a gallows...Mordecai hanged on it: See note on 2:23b. The pole, or some kind of structure made of wood, was to be very tall (75 feet or 25 meters) so that everybody would see Mordecai's dead body.

5:14c

Then go to the banquet with the king and enjoy yourself.”

- After that you will be able to enjoy yourself when you accompany the king to the queen to eat the feast.”

banquet: See note on 1:9.

5:14d

The advice pleased Haman, and he had the gallows constructed.

- Haman was delighted with their idea, so he ordered some men to prepare a tall pole so that he could arrange for Mordecai to die on it.

Esther 6:1

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom

he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:1

That night sleep escaped the king; so he ordered the Book of Records, the Chronicles, to be brought in and read to him.

- ¶ That same night, the king could not sleep, so he told his servants to bring the book in which people had written down all the important things that had happened in his kingdom since he had become king and read it to him.

That night: That is, the same night that Haman was planning to kill Mordecai.

the Book of Records, the Chronicles: This was the record of the important events which had happened since Xerxes became king. It refers to the same book as “the Book of the Chronicles” in 2:23c.

Esther 6:2

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai’s death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:2

And there it was found recorded that Mordecai had exposed Bigthana and Teresh, two of the eunuchs who guarded the king’s entrance, when they had conspired to assassinate King Xerxes.

- As they were reading, they reached the story about Bigthana and Teresh. These were the two palace guards who had planned to kill King Xerxes. They read this story to the king and how Mordecai had reported the plan and so saved the king’s life.

who guarded the king’s entrance: See note on 2:21b.

Esther 6:3

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai’s death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:3a

The king inquired, “What honor or dignity has been bestowed on Mordecai for this act?”

- This reminded the king of what had happened and he asked, “What reward did I give Mordecai for what he did? How did I honor him?”

honor or dignity: These two words are similar in meaning. If you do not have two suitable terms, you may follow the CEV and combine the two:

What has been done to reward Mordecai for this?

6:3b

“Nothing has been done for him,” replied the king’s attendants.

- His servants replied, “He did not receive any reward.”

the king’s attendants: This is the same word as in 2:2a. See the note there.

Esther 6:4

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai’s death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:4a

“Who is in the court?” the king asked.

- ¶ Then the king asked, “Are any of my officials in the palace at the moment?”

6:4b

Now Haman had just entered the outer court of the palace

- At that moment, Haman had just entered the part of the palace outside the king’s private rooms.

Now: This word here does not mean “at the present time.” The BSB has added this word to show that this piece of information is a sort of parenthesis. It is something which has already happened or has just happened. If you have a special word in your language which shows that a sentence is background information, you should use it here.

6:4c

to ask the king to hang Mordecai on the gallows he had prepared for him.

- He had come to ask the king to order someone to hang Mordecai on the tall pole that he had prepared for Mordecai’s death.

to hang Mordecai on the gallows: See note on 2:23b.

Esther 6:6**Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai**

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai’s death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:6a

Haman entered, and the king asked him, “What should be done for the man whom the king is delighted to honor?”

- When Haman came in, the king asked him, “There is a man whom I want to honor. How should I do it?”

the king is delighted to honor: The king is again referring to himself as “the king” not “I.” Translate this in the same way as you have done before. See note on 1:15b.

6:6b

Now Haman thought to himself, “Whom would the king be delighted to honor more than me?”

- Haman thought about it, saying to himself, “The king must be talking about me. There is no one else that he would want to honor.”

Haman thought to himself: What follows this is what Haman was thinking, so he did not speak it aloud. You need to decide whether in your language you can use direct speech for people’s thoughts.

Whom would the king be delighted to honor more than me?: Since this is a rhetorical question, not a real question, it could be translated as a statement. For example: “There is nobody whom the king would want to honor more than me.” Decide whether the question or statement is more natural and more vivid in your language.

Esther 6:8**Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai**

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai’s death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:8a

have them bring a royal robe that the king himself has worn

- Tell your servants to bring one of your own robes, one that you yourself have worn.

a royal robe that the king himself has worn: Choose a word for a long outer garment, like a long coat. This was not just a special garment, but one which the king himself had worn.

6:8b

and a horse on which the king himself has ridden—one with a royal crest placed on its head.

- Then tell them to bring one of your horses, one that you yourself have ridden. Let them put one of your crowns on its head.

a royal crest placed on its head: This is the same word in Hebrew as was used for the queen's crown in 1:11a and 2:17c. See note on 1:11a. Here the crown was attached to the horse's head to show that the horse belonged to the king.

Esther 6:9

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:9a

Let the robe and the horse be entrusted to one of the king's most noble princes.

- Then tell your servants to give the robe and the horse to one of your highest officials

6:9b

Let them array the man the king wants to honor

- and let him dress the man that you want to honor in the robe,

Let them array: There is a textual issue here:

1. The LXX has a singular subject "him." For example, the NRSV has:

Let him robe (GNT, CEV, NLT, NRSV, REB, NJB)

1. The Hebrew text has the plural subject. For example, the ESV has:

Let them dress (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option, as this makes the most sense in context. See the Display.

6:9c

and parade him on the horse through the city square,

- and put him on the horse and lead him through the city.

6:9d

proclaiming before him, 'This is what is done for the man whom the king is delighted to honor!'"

- As they go through the streets the official should call out loudly, 'See the good things the king has done for this man because he wants to honor him.'
- As the official leads him through the streets, he should call out loudly, 'Look how well the king treats the man he wants to honor.'

6:9c–d

The same person (or persons) who was the subject of the verb "array" in 6:9b should be the subject of the verbs "parade" in 6:9c and "proclaiming" in 6:9d.

Esther 6:10

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:10a

"Hurry," said the king to Haman, "and do just as you proposed. Take the robe and the horse

- Then the king ordered Haman, "Hurry and get the robe and the horse.

6:10b

to Mordecai the Jew, who is sitting at the king's gate.

- Do everything you suggested for Mordecai the Jew. You will find him at the palace entrance.

the king's gate: See note on 5:9b. Again, here this refers literally to the entrance to the king's palace.

6:10c

Do not neglect anything that you have suggested."

- Do every single thing that you suggested."

Esther 6:12

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants

to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:12a

Then Mordecai returned to the king's gate.

- ¶ After they had gone through the city, Mordecai returned to the palace entrance.

the king's gate: See note on 5:9b. Again, here this refers literally to the entrance to the king's palace.

6:12b

But Haman rushed home, with his head covered in grief.

- But Haman covered his head from shame and hurried home.

his head covered in grief: This was a sign of grief or of being very upset. Haman was obviously embarrassed by what had happened. Find a natural expression in your language to express this.

Esther 6:13

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:13a

Haman told his wife Zeresh and all his friends everything that had happened.

- He told his wife Zeresh and all his friends everything that had happened to him that day.

6:13b

His advisers and his wife Zeresh said to him, "Since Mordecai, before whom your downfall has begun, is Jewish,

- These wise friends and his wife said to him, "You are already beginning to lose power to Mordecai. He is a Jew

His advisers: This refers to the same group of friends as in 6:13a. The word is literally "wise men."

6:13c

you will not prevail against him—for surely you will fall before him."

- and therefore you will not be able to win against him. He will certainly defeat you."

Esther 6:14

Section 6:1–14: The king honored Mordecai

The same night that Haman was planning Mordecai's death, the king could not sleep. So he told his servants to read to him from the book of the annals, in which the important events of his reign were recorded. One of the events the servants read about was the time when Mordecai had saved his life (see 2:19–23), and the king decided that he ought to reward him. So when Haman arrived the next morning, the king asked him how he thought the king ought to reward a man whom he wanted to honor. Haman suggested some ways to do that, thinking that the king was referring to him. The king then decided to honor Mordecai in those ways, and made Haman carry out his suggestions.

6:14

While they were still speaking with Haman, the king's eunuchs arrived and rushed him to the banquet that Esther had prepared.

- ¶ While they were saying this, the king's servants arrived. They led Haman quickly to the feast that Esther had caused to be prepared.

the banquet that Esther had prepared: See note on 5:4b.

banquet: See note on 1:9.

Esther 7:2

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther's second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he

found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:2a

and as they drank their wine on that second day, the king asked once more,

- As they were drinking wine on that second occasion, the king asked again,

on that second day: This does not mean that the feast lasted 2 days, but that it was the second feast that Esther had held. You could connect this phrase to 7:1, as in the GNT:

And so the king and Haman went to eat with Esther for a second time

7:2b

“Queen Esther, what is your petition? It will be given to you.

- “Queen Esther, what do you want to ask me? I will give whatever you want.

7:2c

What is your request? Even up to half the kingdom, it will be fulfilled.”

- What do you want me to give you? If you ask me to, I will even divide my kingdom, and give you one half.”

7:2b–c

What is your petition?...What is your request?: See note on 5:6b.

Esther 7:3

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:3a

Queen Esther replied, “If I have found favor in your sight, O king,

- Queen Esther replied, “Your Majesty, if you are pleased with me

O king: As usual, you will need to choose the appropriate term in your language for addressing the king.

7:3b

and if it pleases the king,

- and if you are willing to do what I ask,

and if it pleases the king: See note on 1:19a.

7:3c

grant me my life as my petition, and the lives of my people as my request.

- spare my life and the life of the people of my race. This is what I ask you.

petition...request: See note on 5:7.

Esther 7:4

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:4a

For my people and I have been sold out to destruction, death, and annihilation.

- For someone has betrayed me and the people of my race, so that every one of us will be killed and completely destroyed.

have been sold out: This could refer to the money Haman offered to the king (see note on 3:9b) or as a way of saying “betrayed” or “handed over to.” It is probably the latter.

destruction, death, and annihilation: These are translated from the same three Hebrew verbs as in 3:13b. See the note on that verse. Even if you do not use three words in your translation, be sure to use language that is very strong and includes the idea of no Jew being left alive.

7:4b

If we had merely been sold as menservants and maidservants, I would have remained silent,

- If this person had only sold us, both men and women, as slaves, I would not have said anything to you,

7:4c

because no such distress would justify burdening the king.”

- because that would not have been important enough to justify troubling you.”

no such distress would justify burdening the king:

The meaning of this clause in Hebrew is not clear because several of the words have more than one meaning. The two most likely meanings are:

1. If Haman had intended only to sell the Jews as slaves, that would not have been sufficient reason to trouble the king with the problem. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV, CEV, GW)
2. The word translated distress in the BSB can also mean “enemy” and the verb translated burdening can also mean “compensate.” So the expression means that no enemy would be able to compensate for the loss to the king caused by the death of so many of the people in the empire. (NRSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

Esther 7:6

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:6a

Esther replied, “The adversary and enemy is this wicked man—Haman!”

- Esther replied, “The enemy who wants to destroy us is this wicked man, Haman.”

adversary and enemy: These are two words that have similar meaning. If you do not have two words you can use here, you can combine them into one expression.

7:6b

And Haman stood in terror before the king and queen.

- When Esther said this, Haman looked at the king and queen in great fear.

Esther 7:7

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:7a

In his fury, the king arose from drinking his wine and went to the palace garden,

- When the king heard what Esther said, he became very angry. He got up from the meal, left the wine he had been drinking, and went outside into the palace garden.

The king went out of the room because he was very angry with Haman. He needed time to decide what to do about him and how to help Esther.

7:7b

while Haman stayed behind to beg Queen Esther for his life,

- Haman stayed behind in order to beg the queen, Esther, to save his life,

7:7c

for he realized that the king was planning a terrible fate for him.

- because he knew that the king had already decided to kill him.

Esther 7:8

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:8a

Just as the king returned from the palace garden to the banquet hall, Haman was falling on the couch where Esther was reclining.

- ¶ Now Esther was lying on a couch. Haman threw himself down next to her to beg her for mercy. At that very moment, the king came back from the garden into the room where they had been eating.

couch: See note on 1:6c.

7:8b

The king exclaimed, “Would he actually assault the queen while I am in the palace?”

- When the king saw Haman on the couch beside Esther he shouted: “Is this man going to rape the queen even while I am present in the palace with her?”
- When the king saw this, he said loudly: “This man thinks he can rape the queen even while I am here with her in the palace!”

Would he actually assault the queen while I am in the palace?: This is a rhetorical question. The Display shows one way of expressing this as a statement.

7:8c

As soon as the words had left the king’s mouth, they covered Haman’s face.

- As soon as the king said this, the servants took a cloth and covered Haman’s face. This showed that Haman would die.

they covered Haman’s face: Most scholars think that this action showed that Haman was condemned to death. You will need to find some way of making this clear to your readers. The Display shows one way of doing this. However, if you are using footnotes in your translation, it would be better to put this information in a footnote.

Esther 7:9

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:9a

Then Harbonah, one of the eunuchs attending the king, said:

- Then Harbonah, one of the servants who was with the king, said,

7:9b

“There is a gallows fifty cubits high at Haman’s house.

- “Your Majesty, there is already a tall pole, 25 meters high, standing next to Haman’s house.

gallows: See note on 2:23b.

7:9c

He had it built for Mordecai, who gave the report that saved the king.”

- Haman himself caused it to be made, so that he could hang Mordecai, the man who saved your life, on it.”

gave the report that saved the king: This refers to when Mordecai told the king about the plot to kill him and so saved his life. See 2:21–23.

7:9d

“Hang him on it!” declared the king.

- So the king commanded: “Hang Haman on it so that he will die.”

Esther 7:10

Section 7:1–10: The king commanded that Haman should die

When the king and Haman came to Esther’s second feast, Esther begged the king not to allow her and the other Jews to be killed. When the king heard that it was Haman who had ordered their destruction, he was very angry and left the room. When he returned, he found Haman pleading with Esther, but since he was lying on the couch on which Esther also was lying, he suspected him of trying to rape Esther and ordered his death. So Haman was hung on the tall pole which he had had erected for putting Mordecai to death.

7:10a

So they hanged Haman on the gallows he had prepared for Mordecai.

- So they hanged Haman on the pole which he had erected for Mordecai, and there he died.

hanged...on the gallows: See note on 2:23b.

7:10b

Then the fury of the king subsided.

- After that, the king was no longer angry.

Esther 8:1

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:1a

That same day King Xerxes awarded Queen Esther the estate of Haman, the enemy of the Jews.

- ¶ On that same day King Xerxes took everything which had belonged to Haman, the enemy of the Jews, and gave them to Queen Esther.

the estate of Haman: This is literally "the house of Haman" but here it refers to everything that belonged to Haman—land and other possessions.

8:1b

And Mordecai entered the king's presence because Esther had revealed his relation to her.

- Then when Esther told him that Mordecai was one of her relatives, he sent servants to bring Mordecai to him.

Esther 8:2

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:2a

The king removed the signet ring he had recovered from Haman and presented it to Mordecai.

- Then he took his ring off his finger and gave it to Mordecai. This was the same ring that he had previously given to Haman and taken back when he died.

the signet ring: By giving Mordecai his own ring, the king made him the highest official in the land. This was the same ring which he had previously given to Haman. See note on 3:10a.

8:2b

And Esther appointed Mordecai over the estate of Haman.

- Then Esther put Mordecai in charge of everything that had belonged to Haman.

Esther 8:3

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:3a

And once again, Esther addressed the king. She fell at his feet weeping

- ¶ Esther then fell weeping at the king's feet, and once more began to plead with him.

once again: The text does not state when Esther spoke with the king about the Jews. It may have been later that day or some time after that day.

8:3b

and begged him to revoke the evil scheme of Haman the Agagite, which he had devised against the Jews.

- She begged him to stop the evil plan which Haman, the descendant of Agag, had made to kill the Jews.

Agagite: See note on 3:1a.

Esther 8:4

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:4

The king extended the gold scepter toward Esther, and she arose and stood before the king.

- Then the king reached out the gold stick toward Esther, so she got up and stood in front of him.

extended the gold scepter: By doing this, the king was permitting Esther to speak.

the gold scepter: See note on 4:11b.

Esther 8:5

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:5a

“If it pleases the king,” she said, “and if I have found favor in his sight, and the matter seems proper to the king, and I am pleasing in his sight,

- She said, “Your Majesty, if you are willing, and if you are pleased with me, and if you think that it is right to do,

This part of the verse contains four main clauses:

1. **If it pleases the king**
2. **and if I have found favor in his sight**
3. **and the matter seems proper to the king**
4. **and I am pleasing in his sight**

Clause 1, If it pleases the king, is similar in meaning to clause 3, and the matter seems proper to the king, and clause 2, and if I have found favor in his sight, is similar in meaning to clause 4, and I am pleasing in his sight.

You need to decide in your translation whether you should translate each clause separately or whether you should combine clauses. Any of these ways is acceptable, so you can choose the one that can be most easily translated into your language. GNT has translated clauses 1 and 3 separately but combined 2 and 4. You could also combine 1 and 3, then combine 2 and 4, as in the CEV:

I know you will do the right thing, and that you really love me

8:5b

may an order be written to revoke the letters that the scheming Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite, wrote

- tell your secretaries to write a document to cancel the orders in the documents which Haman, son of Hammedatha, the descendant of Agag, planned and wrote.

letters: See note on 1:22a.

Agagite: See note on 3:1a.

8:5c

to destroy the Jews in all the king's provinces.

- In those documents Haman ordered the people to kill all the Jews everywhere in your kingdom.

Esther 8:6

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:6a

For how could I bear to see the disaster that would befall my people?

- Please do this for I cannot bear to see the people of my race suffer in that way.
- For I cannot bear to see such a terrible thing happen to the people of my race.

For: This gives the reason why Esther was making her request to the king in these verses.

how could I bear to see the disaster that would befall my people?: This is a rhetorical question. Decide whether in your language it is better to use the question or statement form. The question in 8:6b is also rhetorical.

how could I bear to see the disaster that would befall my people?: This is a rhetorical question. Decide whether in your language it is better to use the question or statement form. The question in 8:6b is also rhetorical.

8:6b

How could I bear to see the destruction of my kindred?”

- I cannot bear to see people destroy my family like that.”

Esther 8:7

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead

permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:7a

So King Xerxes said to Esther the Queen and Mordecai the Jew,

- ¶ Then King Xerxes said to Queen Esther and to Mordecai, the Jew,

8:7b

“Behold, I have given Haman’s estate to Esther,

- “I gave everything that belonged to Haman to you, Esther,

Haman’s estate: See note on 8:1a.

8:7c

and he was hanged on the gallows

- and I ordered my servants to hang him on the pole so that he died.

hanged on the gallows: See note on 2:23b.

8:7d

because he attacked the Jews.

- I did that because Haman planned to kill the Jews.

because he attacked the Jews: The Hebrew text is more literally “laid hands on the Jews.” Because Haman’s attack on the Jews was still in the future, you may translate this phrase in a different way:

Because Haman was against the Jews (NCV)

Because of his evil plans to kill the Jews (CEV)

General Comment about 8:7b–d

It may be more logical in your language to reverse 8:7b and 8:7c–d. Haman was killed at the end of chapter 7, and then the king gave his property to Esther, so you may want to keep that same order here. GNT does this: “I have hanged Haman for his plot against the Jews, and I have given Esther his property.”

Esther 8:8

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman’s death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman’s order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill

their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

8:8a

Now you may write in the king’s name as you please regarding the Jews,

- Now I give you permission to write another order, one with my authority, to prevent people from killing the Jews. Write it however you think is best.

write in the king’s name: See note on 3:12d.

8:8b

and seal it with the royal signet ring.

- When you have written it, seal it with wax and stamp it with my own ring.

seal it with the royal signet ring: See note on 3:12e.

8:8c

For a decree that is written in the name of the king and sealed with the royal signet ring cannot be revoked.”

- No document written with my authority and sealed with my own ring can be cancelled.”
- If someone writes a document with my authority and seals it with my ring, no one can cancel it.”

For a decree that is written in the name of the king and sealed with the royal signet ring cannot be revoked: The commentators and English versions do not agree on which document the king is referring to here. There are two possibilities:

1. It is a general statement, referring to any order made in the king’s name. In this verse it therefore refers to the order Esther and Mordecai were about to make. Because the king authorized it to be issued, no one would be able to cancel it. This is the best interpretation of this sentence based on its position in the Hebrew text, and it is the one followed by nearly every English version (BSB, NIV, NRSV, CEV, NCV, REB, NLT, NJPS, GW).
2. It refers specifically to the order Haman had issued. The king was saying that he could not cancel it, but he permitted Esther and Mordecai to write something of their own. This interpretation is followed by GNT, which reverses the order of the verse to express this:

But a proclamation issued in the king’s name and stamped with the royal seal cannot be revoked. You may, however, write to the Jews whatever you like; and you may write it in my name and stamp it with the royal seal. (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first option like the majority of the translations.

a decree: See note on 1:19a.

Esther 8:9

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:9a

At once the royal scribes were summoned, and on the twenty-third day of the third month (the month of Sivan),

- ¶ Immediately, that same day, the 23rd day of the 3rd month, the month called Sivan, Esther and Mordecai sent for the people who wrote documents for the king.

royal scribes: See note on 3:12a.

were summoned: The text does not say who summoned the secretaries, but it was probably Mordecai and Esther, since the king had permitted them to issue the order.

Sivan: See the note about Tebeth in 2:16. The month of Sivan was from mid-May to mid-June.

8:9b

they recorded all of Mordecai's orders to the Jews and to the satraps, governors, and princes of the 127 provinces from India to Cush

- They wrote down all the orders that Mordecai told them to write to the Jews and to the officials, governors, and administrators in the 127 provinces of the kingdom, from India all the way to Ethiopia.

satraps: See note on 3:12b.

princes: See note on 1:3b.

from India to Cush: See note on 1:1c.

8:9c

—writing to each province in its own script, to every people in their own language,

- They wrote the documents in the language and way of writing of the people in each part of the kingdom.

writing to each province in its own script, to every people in their own language: The same instructions were given for the writing of these documents as for the original documents which Haman wrote. See 3:12–14.

script: See note on 1:22b.

8:9d

and to the Jews in their own script and language.

- They wrote also to the Jews in their language and way of writing.

Esther 8:10

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:10a

Mordecai wrote in the name of King Xerxes

- Mordecai told them to write them with the authority of King Xerxes.

in the name of King Xerxes: See note on 3:12d. These letters had the same authority as Haman's letters.

8:10b

and sealed it with the royal signet ring.

- Then he sealed the documents with wax and stamped them with the king's ring.

sealed it with the royal signet ring: See note on 3:12e.

8:10c

He sent the documents by mounted couriers

- He gave the documents to messengers to deliver throughout the kingdom.

mounted couriers: This means messengers who rode on horses.

8:10d

riding on swift horses bred from the royal mares.

- These men mounted on horses that could run fast, horses which people had bred especially for the king's service, and left.

swift horses: The meaning of the word the BSB translates as “swift horses” is not certain. Most versions understand it to refer to horses which can run fast, and therefore the messengers could deliver messages throughout the kingdom as quickly as possible.

bred from the royal mares: This is another phrase which is difficult to understand in Hebrew. It probably refers to a group of horses which were specially bred not just for the king himself to ride, but also for officials to ride on state business.

Esther 8:11

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:11a

By these letters the king permitted the Jews in each and every city the right to assemble and defend themselves,

- In these documents it said that the king would allow the Jews in each town to gather together and fight to defend themselves and their families if people attacked them.

letters: See note on 1:22a.

8:11b

to destroy, kill, and annihilate all the forces of any people or province hostile to them, including women and children,

- It said that if people of any race from any province in the kingdom attacked them with weapons, the king would allow them to kill these people and completely destroy them all, men, women and children.

destroy, kill, and annihilate: See notes on 3:13b and 7:4a.

including women and children: The commentaries disagree about which women and children are being referred to. There are two possibilities:

1. It refers to the women and children of their attackers (BSB, NCV, CEV, NJPS, REB, GW, RSV).
2. It refers to the Jewish women and children (NIV, GNT, NLT).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since it is supported by most of the commentaries and is a more natural way to understand the Hebrew.

8:11c

and to plunder their possessions.

- They could also seize and keep for themselves the things which belonged to these enemies.

plunder their possessions: See note on 3:13c.

Esther 8:12

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:12

The single day appointed throughout all the provinces of King Xerxes was the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, the month of Adar.

- The day which Mordecai chose for the Jews throughout King Xerxes' kingdom to protect themselves like this was the 13th day of the 12th month, the month called Adar.

the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, the month of Adar: This was the same day that Haman had chosen for the massacre. See note on 3:7d.

Esther 8:13

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to

cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:13a

A copy of the text of the edict was to be issued in every province

- When the messengers arrived in each province with the documents, they told the officials there to announce the new law to the people.
- In each region, when the officials received their copy of the document, they were ordered to make sure everyone knew what the new law was.

A copy of the text of the edict was to be issued in every province: This is identical to 3:14a. See notes on that verse.

8:13b

and published to all the people, so that the Jews would be ready on that day to avenge themselves on their enemies.

- They were to make sure that people of every race in the kingdom knew the law, so that the Jews could prepare themselves to fight back against their enemies on that day if their enemies attacked them.

avenge themselves on their enemies: The Jews were to be ready to take revenge on anyone who attacked them.

Esther 8:14

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:9–14

There are many similarities between this passage and the section about Haman's plot to kill the Jews. You should compare this passage with 3:12–15.

8:14a

The couriers rode out in haste on their royal horses, pressed on by the command of the king.

- The messengers mounted the king's horses, and, because the order had come from the king, they rode off quickly to deliver the documents.

couriers: See note on 3:13a.

pressed on by the command of the king: See note on 3:15a. Although it was Mordecai who issued the orders, he did so with the authority of the king.

8:14b

And the edict was also issued in the citadel of Susa.

- At the same time, officials also read the document to the people in the city of Susa.

And the edict was also issued in the citadel of Susa: This is similar to 3:15b. See notes on that verse.

Esther 8:15

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:15–17

These verses are in contrast to Esther 4:1–3. Mordecai is dressed in royal robes instead of sackcloth, and there is general rejoicing instead of mourning.

8:15a

Mordecai went out from the presence of the king

- ¶ Then/So Mordecai left the king's presence.

8:15b

in royal garments of blue and white,

- He was wearing blue and white garments like the king wore.
- He was wearing clothing in the king's colors of blue and white.

8:15c

with a large gold crown and a purple robe of fine linen.

- He also wore a coat made of fine purple cloth. On his head he wore a large crown made of gold.

crown: This is not the same word in Hebrew as was used in 1:11a, 2:17c and 6:8b. Perhaps a different word

was used to make clear that Mordecai wasn't wearing the king's crown, but a different sort of hat.

a purple robe of fine linen: This probably means a long cloak or coat, worn over the other garments. It was made of a finely woven material called linen (see note on 1:6a).

purple: see note on 1:6b.

8:15d

And the city of Susa shouted and rejoiced.

- When the people of Susa heard about the new law, they shouted because they were happy.

And the city of Susa shouted and rejoiced: It is not clear how this sentence is connected to the rest of the verse. Some commentators believe that the city rejoiced when they saw Mordecai in his official robes, but it is more likely that this phrase refers back to the news of the new law. When Haman's order was issued, the people of the city were upset (see 3:15), but now they rejoiced.

shouted and rejoiced: You should choose an expression in your language which means that the people made a lot of noise to show how happy they were when they heard the news.

Esther 8:16

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:15–17

These verses are in contrast to Esther 4:1–3. Mordecai is dressed in royal robes instead of sackcloth, and there is general rejoicing instead of mourning.

8:16

For the Jews it was a time of light and gladness, of joy and honor.

- Also the Jews in Susa were very happy and they celebrated with much joy.

the Jews: This probably refers to the Jews in Susa. Verse 17 refers to the rest of the Jews.

light and gladness, of joy and honor: You should choose words that express the joy and relief that the

Jews felt when they heard that they were allowed to defend themselves if people attacked them. The words light, gladness, and joy all have similar meanings.

Esther 8:17

Section 8:1–17: Xerxes allowed the Jews to protect themselves

After Haman's death, the king gave Esther everything that had belonged to Haman and made Mordecai the chief official in the land. Esther asked the king to cancel Haman's order to kill the Jews. The king instead permitted her and Mordecai to send letters in his name allowing the Jews to defend themselves and kill their enemies. The news of this order brought great joy to the Jews.

Paragraph 8:15–17

These verses are in contrast to Esther 4:1–3. Mordecai is dressed in royal robes instead of sackcloth, and there is general rejoicing instead of mourning.

8:17a

In every province and every city, wherever the king's edict and decree reached, there was joy and gladness among the Jews, with feasting and celebrating.

- Everywhere in the kingdom, in every town and province where the messengers took the document containing the king's order, the Jews were very happy when they heard the news and they celebrated with feasts.

the king's edict and decree: See note on 1:20a.

joy and gladness: See note on 8:16.

8:17b

And many of the people of the land themselves became Jews,

- At that time, many people of other races changed their religion and became Jews,

became Jews: That is, they adopted the customs and beliefs of the Jews.

8:17c

because the fear of the Jews had fallen upon them.

- because they were afraid of the Jews.

the fear of the Jews had fallen upon them: That is, because they were afraid of the Jews and what they might do, now that Mordecai had such a high position in the kingdom.

Esther 9:1

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:1a

On the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, the month of Adar, the king's command and edict were to be executed.

- ¶ The 13th day of Adar, the 12th month, arrived. This was the day when the Jews were to do what the king's document ordered.

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

edict: See note on 1:20a.

9:1b

On this day the enemies of the Jews had hoped to overpower them,

- This had been the day when the enemies of the Jews had hoped to gain control over them.

9:1c

but their plan was overturned and the Jews overpowered those who hated them.

- But the opposite happened. Instead, the Jews gained control over those who hated them.

their plan was overturned: This means that the opposite happened. The Jews defeated their enemies, instead of their enemies defeating them.

overpowered: This means “gained control over, got them in their power.” This is the same verb in Hebrew as the BSB translated “overpower” in 9:1b.

Esther 9:2

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:2a

In each of the provinces of King Xerxes, the Jews assembled in their cities to attack those who sought to harm them.

- Everywhere in the kingdom of King Xerxes, the Jews gathered together in the towns where they lived and attacked the people who wanted to destroy them.

9:2b

No man could withstand them, because the fear of them had fallen upon all peoples.

- No one was able to oppose the Jews, because the people of all the other races were afraid of them.

No man could withstand them: This means that no one was able to resist the Jews or successfully oppose them.

Esther 9:3

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:3–4

officials: See note on 1:3a.

satraps: See note on 3:12b.

9:3

And all the officials of the provinces, the satraps, the governors, and the king's administrators helped the Jews, because the fear of Mordecai had fallen upon them.

- Even the officials, the governors and all the other people who worked for the king, supported the Jews, because they were afraid of Mordecai.

Esther 9:5

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:5a

The Jews put all their enemies to the sword, killing and destroying them,

- ¶ The Jews attacked all their enemies with swords and killed them.

all their enemies: This is hyperbole (exaggeration for emphasis). It means very many people.

killing and destroying: These two words mean the same thing, so they have been reduced to one word in the Display.

9:5b

and they did as they pleased to those who hated them.

- They treated them as they wanted to.
- They showed them no mercy.

those who hated them: This refers to the same group of people as “their enemies” in 9:5a.

Esther 9:6

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:6

In the citadel of Susa, the Jews killed and destroyed five hundred men,

- They killed 500 men in the city of Susa alone.

citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

killed and destroyed: See note on 9:5a.

Esther 9:7

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:7–10a

These verses contain a list of Haman’s sons, who were included among the people whom the Jews killed that day in Susa. You may wish to combine the verses as the Display has done (also GNT, CEV).

9:7–10a

including Parshandatha, Dalphon, Aspatha, Poratha, Adalia, Aridatha, Parmashta, Arisai, Aridai, and Vaizatha. They killed these ten sons of Haman son of Hammedatha, the enemy of the Jews,

- Among the people they killed were the 10 sons of Haman, son of Hammadatha, the enemy of the Jews. Their names were Parshandatha, Dalphon, Aspatha, Poratha, Adalia, Aridatha, Parmashta, Arisai, Aridai and Vaizatha.

Esther 9:10

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:10b

but they did not lay a hand on the plunder.

- However, they did not take for themselves any of the things belonging to the people they had killed.

lay a hand on: That is, “take for themselves” or “seize.”

plunder: See note on 3:13c.

The Jews did not seize their enemies’ property, although the king had permitted this (see 8:11).

Esther 9:11

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:11

On that day the number of those killed in the citadel of Susa was reported to the king,

- ¶ On that same day people told the king how many people the Jews had killed in Susa.

citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

Esther 9:12

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:12a

who said to Queen Esther, “In the citadel of Susa the Jews have killed and destroyed five hundred men, including Haman’s ten sons.

- So the king said to Queen Esther, “Here in the city of Susa alone the Jews have killed 500 men, including the 10 sons of Haman.

In the citadel of Susa: See note on 1:2.

9:12b

What have they done in the rest of the royal provinces?

- They must have killed many more elsewhere in my kingdom.

What have they done in the rest of the royal provinces?: This is a rhetorical question. It means that if the Jews had killed 500 people in just one city, they

must have killed many more than 500 in all the towns throughout the kingdom.

9:12c

Now what is your petition? It will be given to you. And what further do you request? It will be fulfilled.”

- What do you want now? I will give it to you. What more do you want me to do? I will do it for you.”

These words are similar to what the king said in 5:6 and 7:2. See the notes for those verses.

Esther 9:13

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:13a

Esther replied, “If it pleases the king, may the Jews in Susa also have tomorrow to carry out today’s edict,

- Esther replied, “Your Majesty, if you agree, permit the Jews here in Susa to kill more of their enemies tomorrow as the law allowed them to do today.

If it pleases the king: See note on 1:19a.

edict: See note on 1:20a.

9:13b

and may the bodies of Haman’s ten sons be hanged on the gallows.”

- Also allow us to hang the corpses of Haman’s 10 sons on long poles.”

be hanged on the gallows: See note on 2:23b. Here however it was not a method of execution, since Haman’s sons were already dead (see 9:7–10). It was their corpses that Esther wanted displayed on the gallows, as a warning to other people.

Esther 9:14

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:14a

So the king commanded that this be done.

- So the king ordered his officials to do what Esther had asked.

9:14b

An edict was issued in Susa,

- The secretaries wrote another document and officials made sure everyone in Susa knew what it said.

edict: See note on 1:20a.

9:14c

and they hanged the ten sons of Haman.

- Other people hung the corpses of Haman’s 10 sons on long poles.

Esther 9:15

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:15a

On the fourteenth day of the month of Adar, the Jews in Susa came together again

- So the next day, the 14th day of the month called Adar, the Jews in Susa gathered together again.

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

9:15b

and put to death three hundred men there,

- This time they killed 300 men in the city.

9:15c

but they did not lay a hand on the plunder.

- However, again they did not take for themselves any of the things belonging to the people they had killed.

but they did not lay a hand on the plunder: See notes on 9:10b. The same phrase is repeated here.

Esther 9:16

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:16a

The rest of the Jews in the royal provinces also assembled to defend themselves

- ¶ While all this was happening in Susa, the rest of the Jews who lived in the other parts of the kingdom also gathered together so that they could protect themselves and their families.

9:16b
and rid themselves of their enemies. They killed 75,000 who hated them,

- They killed 75,000 of the people who hated them and so got rid of their enemies.

and rid themselves of their enemies: The main difficulty in translating this verse is to decide how to relate this clause to the rest of the verse. All five clauses in this verse are connected by the simple Hebrew conjunction translated as “and.” There is no further indication how rid themselves of their enemies is related to the clauses which precede it and the one which follows it. So different versions have chosen different grammatical structures and punctuation to show the relationship between the clauses. There are two main interpretations:

1. Killing their enemies was the way in which the Jews got relief from their enemies, as in the GNT:

They rid themselves of their enemies by killing seventy-five thousand people who hated them (GNT, NJPS, NLT)

1. The Jews gathered together to protect themselves and to kill their enemies, as in the NCV:

the Jewish people in the king’s empire also met to protect themselves and get rid of their enemies (BSB, GW, NCV)

Both structures are possible from the Hebrew. The Display follows GNT and is the recommended interpretation.

rid themselves of: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as rid themselves of could be translated “get rid of” or “free themselves from.”

9:16c
but they did not lay a hand on the plunder.

- However, they too did not take for themselves anything belonging to the people they had killed.

but they did not lay a hand on the plunder: This is again the same phrase as in 9:10b. See the notes for that verse.

Esther 9:17

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:17a

This was done on the thirteenth day of the month of Adar,

- This happened on the 13th day of the month called Adar.

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

9:17b

and on the fourteenth day they rested,

- Then the next day, the 14th day, they rested after their fighting

9:17c

making it a day of feasting and joy.

- and joyfully celebrated with feasts.

a day of feasting and joy: It was a day when the Jews held feasts and joyfully celebrated their victory over their enemies.

Esther 9:18

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:18a

The Jews in Susa, however, had assembled on the thirteenth and the fourteenth days of the month.

- However, the Jews in Susa had been fighting on the 14th as well as the 13th.

9:18b

So they rested on the fifteenth day,

- So they did not rest from fighting until the 15th.

they rested: See note on 9:17b.

9:18c

making it a day of feasting and joy.

- That day they joyfully celebrated with feasts.

making it a day of feasting and joy: This is a repeat of 9:17c.

Esther 9:19

Section 9:1–19: The Jews killed their enemies

When the chosen day arrived, the Jews organized themselves, fought their enemies, and killed many of them. Then Esther begged the king to allow the Jews in Susa to fight their enemies again on the following day. He agreed. After that the Jews celebrated.

9:19a

This is why the rural Jews, who live in the villages, observe the fourteenth day of the month of Adar as a day of joy and feasting.

- That is why the Jews who live in the smaller villages hold their celebrations on the 14th day of the month called Adar. They joyfully celebrate with feasts

the rural Jews, who live in the villages: The word which the BSB translates as villages means a small town or village which did not have a wall around it as bigger towns had.

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

a day of joy and feasting: See note on 9:17c.

9:19b

It is a holiday for sending gifts to one another.

- and they give gifts of food to one another on that day.

gifts: Literally “part, portion.” The gifts were mainly of food, hence many versions translate this word “gifts of food.” See 9:19 in GNT, CEV, NRSV. The BSB translates the same word as “gifts” in 9:22d. It is recommended that you translate this word “gifts” in both verses, as the BSB does.

Esther 9:20

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:20a

Mordecai recorded these events

- ¶ Mordecai wrote down all that had happened.

these events: This probably refers to the massacre by the Jews and not to all the events recorded in Esther.

9:20b

and sent letters to all the Jews in all the provinces of King Xerxes, both near and far,

- Then he sent letters to all the Jews everywhere in the kingdom of Xerxes, whether they lived near Susa or far away.

Esther 9:21

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:21

to establish among them an annual celebration on the fourteenth and fifteenth days of the month of Adar

- In these letters he told them that each year on the 14th and 15th day of the month called Adar, they were to celebrate

the fourteenth and fifteenth days: According to the letter Mordecai wrote, the Jews were to celebrate the feast of Purim on both days.

Adar: See note on 3:7d.

Esther 9:22

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:22a

as the days on which the Jews gained rest from their enemies

- because this was the time when they, the Jews, got rid of their enemies

gained rest from their enemies: See note on 9:16b.

9:22b

and the month in which their sorrow turned to joy and their mourning into a holiday.

- and because this was the month when they had stopped being sad and became joyful; they had stopped weeping and began to celebrate.

their sorrow turned to joy and their mourning into a holiday: There are two parallel expressions in the Hebrew:

their sorrow was turned into joy

their mourning into a holiday

You could also combine these two expressions into one, as in the GNT:

this was a month that had been turned from a time of grief and despair into a time of joy and happiness

9:22c

He wrote that these were to be days of feasting and joy,

- So he told them to celebrate these days joyfully with feasts

He wrote: The BSB has added this to remind readers that this was still part of the instructions Mordecai gave in his letter.

days of feasting and joy: See note on 9:17c.

9:22d

of sending gifts to one another and to the poor.

- and by giving gifts of food to each other and also giving things to the poor people.
- and by exchanging gifts of food with each other and providing for the poor people.

sending gifts to one another: This is the same expression as 9:19b and should be translated in the same way in both verses, since it refers to the same action.

gifts...to the poor: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates “gifts” is a general word which is related to the verb “to give.” The important thing is that, whereas the Jews were to exchange gifts of food with one another, when they gave to the poor they were not to expect a gift in return.

Esther 9:24

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:24a

For Haman son of Hammedatha, the Agagite, the enemy of all the Jews, had plotted against the Jews to destroy them

- ¶ So this is why the Jews celebrated: Haman, son of Hammedatha, descendant of Agag, was an enemy of all the Jews and he had planned to destroy them.

For: This introduces a summary of the first eight chapters of Esther. It gives once more the reason for the festival of Purim and why it had that name. It may be what Mordecai wrote in his account (see 9:20).

Agagite: See note on 3:1a.

9:24b

and had cast the Pur (that is, the lot) to crush and destroy them.

- He cast lots called “pur” in order to know the day he should choose to kill them all.
- He wanted to know the best day to do this, so he cast lots called “pur.”

Pur: See note on 3:7b.

Esther 9:25

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:25a

But when it came before the king,

- But when the king heard about the plot,
- When the king heard that Haman planned to kill the Jews,

when it came before the king: Literally “when she came before the king.” It is not clear to whom the feminine pronoun “she” refers. There are two possibilities:

1. The word it to refer back to Haman’s plot, as in the BSB. This is grammatically possible because the Hebrew word translated “plot” is of feminine gender and so the pronoun used in this verse would be correct. (BSB, NCV, GW, REB)
2. The word it, which is feminine in Hebrew, refers to Esther. This seems logical because of what happened earlier in the story, but grammatically it is unlikely since Esther has not been mentioned by name since 9:13. For example, the GNT has:

But Esther went to the king (CEV, GNT, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow the BSB (interpretation 1).

9:25b

he commanded by letter that the wicked scheme which Haman had devised against the Jews should come back upon his own head,

- he wrote an order, saying that his officials should do the same evil thing to Haman that he had planned to do to the Jews
- he told his secretaries to write his command that his officials should treat Haman in the same evil way that he had planned to treat the Jews

should come back upon his own head: That is, that he should suffer the very same fate that he had planned for the Jews.

9:25c

and that he and his sons should be hanged on the gallows.

- and that they should hang Haman and his ten sons on long poles.

hanged on the gallows: This refers back to two different events, those recorded in 7:9-10 and 9:13-14.

Esther 9:26

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:26a

Therefore these days are called Purim, from the word Pur.

- Because the lot which Haman cast was called “pur,” the days when the Jews celebrate this event are called Purim.

Therefore: This part of the verse is a parenthesis and refers back to 9:24b. You may need to state this reference explicitly. The Display shows one way to do this.

Purim: This is the plural form of “pur” in Hebrew. See note on 3:7b.

9:26b

Because of all the instructions in this letter,

- The Jews accepted what Mordecai had written in the letter.

9:26b–9:27c is one sentence in the BSB and most other versions. It is long and complex, so you may need to divide it into shorter sentences before you translate it. The Display shows one way to do this.

9:26c

and because of all they had seen

- They remembered what they had seen

9:26d

and experienced,

- and what had happened to them.

Esther 9:27

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:27a

the Jews bound themselves to establish the custom

- Therefore they decided that they would always celebrate this festival

9:27b

that they and their descendants and all who join them should not fail to celebrate these two days at the appointed time each and every year,

- and that they would make sure their descendants and all those who would become Jews would celebrate it with them on these two days each year.

and all who join them: This refers to people from other races who would change their religion and become Jews. See 8:17.

9:27c

according to their regulation.

- They agreed to celebrate the festival the way Mordecai had instructed them to and on the days he had chosen.

at the appointed time each and every year, according to their regulation: That is, exactly as Mordecai had instructed in his letter.

Esther 9:28

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of

the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:28a

These days should be remembered and celebrated by every generation, family, province, and city,

- They decided that every Jewish family everywhere in the kingdom, in every town and province, both now and in the future, should remember these events by celebrating the festival.

by every generation: This refers to the future as well as the present. You could state this explicitly, as in the GNT:

“of every future generation

9:28b

so that these days of Purim should not fail to be observed among the Jews, nor should the memory of them fade from their descendants.

- They decided that the Jews and their descendants should never forget the things that had happened and they should never stop celebrating the festival of Purim.

Esther 9:29

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:29

So Queen Esther daughter of Abihail, along with Mordecai the Jew, wrote with full authority to confirm this second letter concerning Purim.

- ¶ Then Queen Esther, the daughter of Abihail, used her authority as queen and wrote another letter, helped by Mordecai the Jew. In it, she confirmed what Mordecai had written earlier about the festival of Purim.

There are many problems in this verse, and if you compare different English versions you will see that they differ from each other in many ways. These Notes give some of the reasons for the differences.

along with Mordecai the Jew: Some commentators and English versions change the place of this phrase

in the verse (see, for example, NJPS, CEV, REB) or omit it altogether (JB, which follows the LXX). However, it is recommended that you follow the BSB, which is the majority view and the clearest way of understanding the Hebrew text.

with full authority: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates “authority” literally means “strength, power.” Here it is referring to the authority Esther had as queen.

to confirm this second letter: This is a very difficult expression to understand. It seems clear from the context that this second letter refers to the letter Esther (and Mordecai) were now writing. The first letter was, then, the letter Mordecai wrote in 9:20. This is the view of most commentators. It is difficult, however, to understand how a letter can confirm itself. It would make more sense if this letter was written to confirm the letter which Mordecai had written (in 9:20). This is how a number of versions have translated it (GNT, NCV, NJPS). If a literal translation of this phrase would be difficult to understand in your language, you could follow one of these versions. See, for example, the NCV:

they wrote to prove the first letter was true

Purim: See note on 3:7b.

Esther 9:30

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:30

And Mordecai sent letters with words of peace and truth to all the Jews in the 127 provinces of the kingdom of Xerxes,

- So Mordecai sent these letters with kind and sincere words to all the Jews in the 127 provinces of Xerxes’ kingdom, saying

And Mordecai sent: The Hebrew is more literally “and he sent.” From the context, it means Mordecai, so this is how the BSB has translated it (also NCV, GW). However other versions understand the verb to be a passive (RSV, GNT, CEV, NJPS, NLT, REB).. If you have a passive in your language, it is recommended that you use it here:

letters were sent

peace: The Hebrew word here, šalom, is often translated “peace,” but it is a word that has many different meanings. Here the literal expression “words of peace” probably means “kind words” or “friendly words.”

truth: Here the literal expression “words of truth” probably means “sincere words.”

Esther 9:31

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:31a

in order to confirm these days of Purim at their appointed time,

- that the Jews should make an agreement to celebrate the festival of Purim at the time which Mordecai had chosen,

Purim: See note on 3:7b.

9:31b

just as Mordecai the Jew and Queen Esther had established them

- just as Mordecai the Jew and Queen Esther had ordered them to.

9:31c

and had committed themselves and their descendants to the times of fasting and lamentation.

- They should make an agreement to celebrate Purim on those days each year just as they had made an agreement that they and their descendants should keep certain other days for fasting and crying to God.

the times of fasting and lamentation: The Hebrew is more literally “words of fasting and lamentation.” It probably is a way of referring to certain Jewish holidays. The Jews were in the habit of commemorating certain traumatic events in their history by holding annual fasts. So this verse is saying that they should establish this holiday (Purim) just as they had established these other holidays.¹ Scholars differ in how they believe this phrase should be connected grammatically to the rest of the verb and whether they believe this phrase refers to Purim itself or to

other holidays which the Jews celebrated. Many English versions are unclear. The majority interpretation is the one discussed in the Notes. It is followed by NJPS, NIV, RSV, GW and GNT and takes the phrase “times of fasting and lamentation” as the object of the verb which the BSB translates “established.” The JB follows a different interpretation which believes that the verse says that fasting and lamentation were to be included in the way Purim was to be celebrated. So the JB has “with additional ordinances for fasts and lamentations.”

fasting: See note on 4:3b.

lamentation: This refers to pleading with God for something with tears, not to mourning for the dead.

Esther 9:32

Section 9:20–32: How the Jews began to celebrate the festival called Purim

Mordecai sent out letters to tell the Jews to hold a celebration each year to remember the victory of the Jews over their enemies. This annual festival was called Purim because Haman had cast lots called purim to choose the best day to kill the Jews. Jews still celebrate this festival today.

9:32a

So Esther’s decree confirmed these regulations about Purim,

- The orders which Esther wrote in her letter confirmed the rules that the Jews were to keep about celebrating the festival of Purim.

decree: See note on 1:19a.

these regulations about Purim: That is, the rules about how and when they were to celebrate the festival.

9:32b

which were written into the record.

- And Esther told the secretaries to write the orders down in the official books.

Esther 10:1

Section 10:1–3: Mordecai received honor in all the kingdom of Xerxes

The book began with a reference to the greatness of King Xerxes. It ends with how the king honored Mordecai, one of the heroes of the story.

10:1

Now King Xerxes imposed tribute throughout the land, even to its farthest shores.

- ¶ King Xerxes demanded that the people everywhere in his kingdom even as far as the edge of the sea, should pay taxes to him.

tribute: The Hebrew is more “forced labor.” However the word also came to mean tribute, a sort of tax which the king made the people throughout his kingdom pay. Because of the expenses of the long war against Greece, the king needed money. These taxes would have been paid mainly by food which the people grew or by animals which they reared.

throughout the land, even to its farthest shores:

Literally “upon the land and the regions of the sea.” Scholars differ in how they understand this, especially the expression “the regions of the sea.” The two main possibilities are:

1. “Regions of the sea” means the coast, as distinguished from the interior (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NLT).
2. “Regions of the sea” means the islands, as distinguished from the mainland (NJPS, GW, CEV, JB).

The expression “regions of the sea” can mean either. The important thing is that the expression “upon the land and the regions of the sea” means that the whole empire was included, and you should make sure that your translation makes this clear.

Esther 10:2

Section 10:1–3: Mordecai received honor in all the kingdom of Xerxes

The book began with a reference to the greatness of King Xerxes. It ends with how the king honored Mordecai, one of the heroes of the story.

10:2a

And all of Mordecai’s powerful and magnificent accomplishments,

- The royal secretaries wrote down all the great things the king had done throughout the time he was king,

all of Mordecai’s powerful and magnificent accomplishments: Literally “all the work of his power and his authority.” The versions understand the pronoun “his” in two ways:

1. It refers to King Xerxes. This interpretation is followed by the majority of English versions: (CEV, GNT, GW, JB, NCV, NIV, NLT, REB)
2. It refers to Mordecai. BSB follows this interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), like the majority of English versions.

powerful and magnificent: The two words powerful and magnificent are synonyms. They refer to the great things the king did.

10:2b

together with the full account of the greatness to which the king had raised him,

- and also all about how great Mordecai had become because the king had honored him.

10:2c

are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Media and Persia?

- The secretaries wrote all these things in the book about what the kings of Media and Persia had done.

This is a rhetorical question. The Display shows one way of expressing it as a statement.

Book of the Chronicles: See note on 2:23c.